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WHOM DOES THE CITY ALLOW TO READ?

Seven Indian cities read along the country's two founding public-library lineages: the Madras cess (Chennai) and the Bombay grant (Mumbai). Between them, the reading commons is kept on paper while it is withdrawn as a public, first from the wards where the most caste-marked readers live.

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Whom Does the City Allow to Read?

Caste, Democracy, and the Public Library in the Indian City

RIGHT TO READ CAMPAIGN

Abstract

In modern India the public library was meant as an instrument of emancipation: access to the printed word, a route out of caste hierarchy. This paper reads seven city library systems (Ahmedabad, Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Kolkata, and Mumbai) against the country's two founding public-library lineages: the Madras model (Tamil Nadu, 1948), which funds reading with a dedicated, buoyant cess, and the Bombay model (Maharashtra, 1967), which refused the cess for a fixed, un-indexed grant. The two diverge sharply. Chennai shows the Madras lineage still working: dense, disclosed, reachable, because the law pays for it. Mumbai shows the Bombay lineage decayed: a 2024 amendment answers its fiscal shortfall by making library-council seats nominated rather than elected, and opening the fund to corporate donation. The remaining five cities sit between these poles, held back either by cess revenue their municipal corporations withhold or by no working funding instrument at all. Across all seven, the library is unmade by two techniques: non-disclosure of branch-level service, and identity-gating of who counts as "the public" through Aadhaar, guarantors, and deposits. Both fall on the same residents. Mumbai's ward-level caste data lets this exclusion be measured directly: Scheduled-Caste and Scheduled-Tribe-reserved wards are reached last. An institution that survives on paper while receding in practice has not failed. It has been converted from an instrument meant to dissolve caste into one that administers it. Whether it recedes turns, above all, on whether a city taxes itself to keep it.

KEYWORDS public libraries · India · caste · democracy · urban inequality · Ahmedabad · Delhi · Bengaluru · Hyderabad · Chennai · Kolkata · Mumbai · library cess · Madras model · Bombay model · library access · transparency

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1 Introduction and Measurement Frame

Reading, in modern India, was never neutral leisure. From the nineteenth-century anti-caste reformers to the twentieth-century literacy and library movements, access to the printed word was claimed as a route out of caste hierarchy, and the free public library became its civic form. It is against that inheritance — the library as an instrument of emancipation, open to anyone who walks in — that this paper reads seven contemporary Indian city library systems: Ahmedabad, Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Kolkata, and Mumbai. It finds the inheritance being reversed: the library kept intact as an institution while it is withdrawn as a public, hollowed by a disclosure regime that hides the loss and a documentary gate that screens its readers by class and caste.

The seven cities are read along a single organizing axis, and that axis is the country's own legislative history. Independent India built its public-library law from two founding statutes, and they chose opposite ways to pay for reading. The first was the **Madras model** — the Tamil Nadu (Madras) Public Libraries Act, 1948, India's first public-library statute, Ranganathan-drafted, which created a statutory library authority and funded it with a dedicated, buoyant **library cess** on property tax: the reading commons paid for out of ring-fenced public revenue that grows with the city. The second was the **Bombay model** — the Maharashtra Public Libraries Act, 1967, which built the same institutional scaffolding but refused the cess, funding libraries instead from a fixed, un-indexed government grant floor: the reading commons carried on a decaying annual sum and, latterly, on private money. Chennai is the living case of the first; Mumbai of the second. Every other city here sits somewhere on the range between them — Karnataka and Telangana copied the Madras cess but let their municipal corporations pocket it (Bengaluru, Hyderabad); West Bengal copied the Madras Act but dropped the cess (Kolkata); Gujarat legislated with no funding instrument at all (Ahmedabad); and Delhi is run directly by the Union. The question the paper puts to each is the same — whether a resident, and especially a caste-marked resident, can find, reach, and enter a working public library — but the two lineages set the fiscal terms on which each city answers it.

Delhi and Mumbai each carry a further complication the resident denominator does not capture. Delhi Public Library is a Union-linked system governed through the Delhi Library Board and funded through the Ministry of Culture: not simply a municipal case but a capital-city special case, like Washington, Canberra, Ottawa, Jakarta, or Singapore, where the capital function and the local public-service function are institutionally tangled. And every one of these cities serves large non-resident publics — students, job seekers, visitors, researchers, migrants, and temporary residents — for whom the public library is civic infrastructure the resident count alone cannot measure. Until city-bounded use data is isolated, foreign-visitor figures such as Delhi's 1.83 million foreign tourist visits in 2023 and Gujarat's 2.274 million in 2024 are used only as gateway-exposure proxies, not as literal municipal-limit counts.

A public library is civic infrastructure, not a book warehouse. Ranganathan's laws put use at the centre of the institution (Ranganathan 1931), and the IFLA-UNESCO manifesto frames the public library as a local institution for education, information, culture, and democratic participation (International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions and UNESCO 2022). Contemporary work on libraries as social infrastructure makes the same point in urban terms: the branch matters because it is a low-threshold public place where access to knowledge, space, and social life can be distributed (Mattern 2014; Klinenberg 2018; Audunson 2005).

Three instruments set that standard. IFLA's Library Map of the World collects library data from national associations on a common template — service points, staff, registered users, visits, loans, expenditure — so that a system can be described and compared as a service rather than as a stock of buildings (International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions 2026). ISO 2789 standardises the definitions beneath those counts: what registers as a service point, a loan, a visit, a registered user (ISO 2789 2022). ISO 11620 turns the counts into performance indicators — measures of how far a service actually reaches the population it is meant to serve (ISO 11620 2023). Together they move the question a city must answer from institutional existence to service performance: not whether it runs a library department, but whether residents and non-resident publics can reach and use staffed, open, adequately resourced service points. The fields the frame expects a system to report are precisely the ones Ahmedabad and Delhi mostly do not:

Metric	Why it matters
Libraries or service points	Establishes the physical and mobile service network.
Libraries with internet access	Tests whether the library is also a digital access point.
Full-time staff	Tests whether the network has human service capacity.
Volunteers	Captures supplementary labor, but should not substitute for staff.
Registered users	Measures active membership or registration stock.
Physical visits	Measures actual use of library premises.
Physical loans	Measures circulation of physical material.
E-book loans	Measures digital lending.
Audio-book loans	Measures accessible and digital lending.
Downloads	Measures broader digital content use.

The access model is deliberately conservative. Distance to the nearest library is only a proxy. A defensible model needs demand origins, travel time, catchments, supply capacity, and distance decay (Penchansky and Thomas 1981; Guagliardo 2004; Luo and Wang 2003; Luo and Qi 2009). The spatial results below should therefore be read as first-pass access diagnostics, not final capacity-weighted service claims. More broadly, the city readings that follow are offered as explorations meant to ask sharper questions of a badly disclosed institution, not as truth-value verdicts on any one city. Much of the assembled data is an explicit lower bound — an OpenStreetMap or Google-Places-findable surface, a Census-apportioned ward attribute, a transit layer built from Metro and bus stops that omits the suburban rail that in fact carries these cities — and each strong claim is held to what its data can carry, with the residual named as a limit rather than dressed as a result.

For Ahmedabad and Delhi, the decisive missing layer is branch-level service disclosure: seating capacity, opening hours, weekly hours, branch collection size, collection type, internet access, staff posted, visits, loans, and programs by location.

A library's "public-ness" is not one quality but a chain of conditions, each of which must hold for the institution to work as public infrastructure: it must be **disclosed** (its service visible enough to judge), **reachable** (within ordinary travel of the people it serves), **enterable** (open without a test of documents, money, or social standing), **governed** accountably, and **planned as infrastructure** at all rather than maintained as a legacy department. The argument runs through these conditions in turn; the international systems enter where each is most sharply at stake — Toronto on disclosure, the membership regimes on entry, Singapore and Jakarta on governance, Medellín and Shenzhen on civic intent.

2 The Public Library in the Postcolonial City

Delhi and Ahmedabad are the two cities through which India most often stages its arrival for an external gaze. Delhi hosted the 2010 Commonwealth Games; Ahmedabad, declared India's first UNESCO World Heritage City in 2017, has since been chosen to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games and made the centrepiece of the country's 2036 Olympic bid. The investment such spectacle commands flows readily to shiny capital infrastructure — stadiums, riverfronts, expressways, the world's largest cricket ground — and far less readily to the unglamorous public goods that constitute everyday urban life: parks, footpaths, buses, and the public library among them. To ask what becomes of the library in these cities is to ask what the showcase city does with the commons it does not photograph.

Beneath the spectacle runs an accumulation logic that Marxist geographers have placed at the centre of how the contemporary city is read. The showcase city is also an engine of land and financial accumulation — the urban built as a fix for surplus capital (Harvey 2012) — and India's recent urbanism turns land itself into a financial asset (Searle 2016), with the state brokering it for real-estate capital and dispossessing those in the way (Levien 2018) and public infrastructure recast as a tradable asset class rather than a citizens' commons (Bear 2017, 2020). The Mumbai–Ahmedabad high-speed line will fold Ahmedabad into Mumbai's property orbit; GIFT City stages a finance enclave beside it; Delhi's three airports and regional rapid-transit corridors are land-value machines as much as transit. We do not anatomise this here, only mark its weight: a city tuned for accumulation keeps little room on its balance sheet for the unprofitable commons — and it is there, in the commons being squeezed out, that the library's anti-caste promise was meant to live.

Scholarship on the Indian city runs along two tracks, and the public library falls between them. One track anatomises the high-modernist planning state — the developmental promise that zoned, built, and then failed to deliver. The other, following Ravi Sundaram, finds in the postcolonial city a "pirate modernity": where the planned city fails, residents improvise, appropriate, and circulate their own access to media and the urban, and the city's centre of gravity shifts "from planning to information" (Sundaram 2009, 2017). Both accounts are indispensable, and both are organised around class, informality, and aesthetics. D. Asher Ghertner's Delhi — where an "aesthetic governmentality" learns to calculate without numbers and a gentrified state clears the poor for a world-class future — is read through property and class, not caste (Ghertner 2010, 2011); Ayona Datta's "smart urban age" governs through an aspirational future (Datta 2019). The injunction to read the Southern city on its own terms (Bhan 2019) and the subaltern urbanism of its informal majority (Roy 2011) have reshaped the field — yet caste sits at its edge, rarely its object.

That omission matters, because for Dalits and the marginalised the Indian city has delivered neither modernity in full. It did not deliver the high-modernist public good: the planned library, like the planned school, was sited where the upper-caste city already was, and the Dalit migrant arrived as "footloose labour" (Breman 1996). Juned Shaikh's history of twentieth-century Bombay shows the rest — industrial capitalism and the caste system in "symbiosis," Dalit neighbourhoods marked as slums to be cleared, and "language and literature" made a battleground of Dalit cultural politics (Shaikh 2021). Banerjee and Mehta find the same logic in contemporary Ahmedabad: city-making does not dissolve caste in the "liberating space of anonymity" it promised, but masks and intensifies it into a "post-liberalisation Dalit ghetto" (Banerjee and Mehta 2017). Nor does the marginalised reader receive the pirate-modern compensation: you cannot improvise past a biometric, a guarantor, or a refundable deposit the way Sundaram's subjects pirate a cable line, and the digital reading layer that now displaces the branch runs on the same mobile-and-identity rails, along "gender- and caste-based fault lines" (Mukherjee 2026). The "right to be counted" that Sanjeev Routray's Delhi poor must fight for (Routray 2022) is, at the library counter, exactly the right the gate withholds. This double foreclosure — denied the planned institution and the informal workaround at once — is what frames that read only for class do not see.

Ambedkar gives the stakes their sharpest form. For him the village was "a sink of localism, a den of ignorance, narrow-mindedness and communalism," the engine of untouchability, where tight and segregated association marks the Untouchable out (Ambedkar, n.d.); the city, larger and more anonymous, was where caste might loosen and a "corporate feeling of oneness" become thinkable (Cháirez-Garza 2014). The free public library is the civic form of that urban promise — a place where reading, long withheld by caste, opens to anyone who enters. The promise was always conditional in practice. Shailaja Paik records Dalit girls admitted to school yet made to sit at its threshold, present in the institution and excluded from its use, caste and gender compounding into a "double discrimination" (Paik 2014, 2022). Sharika Thiranagama finds that even the celebrated "caste-free" library publics of Kerala reconstitute caste rather than abolish it — "not all are coming to the library … I can't really say that there is a free space for Dalit castes" (Thiranagama 2022, 2026; Harikrishnan 2022). The library admits and excludes in the same gesture.

Seeing how requires giving up the habit of counting infrastructure as a stock of buildings. AbdouMaliq Simone's "people as infrastructure" relocates the infrastructural to social practice — the provisional collaborations through which residents provision what the state does not (Simone 2004); Susan Leigh Star observes that infrastructure turns visible only when it breaks (Star 1999), which is why a service kept off the record can be withdrawn without anyone seeing it go; and Graham and Marvin describe how networked public infrastructures "splinter," binding the served districts while bypassing the poor (Graham and Marvin 2001). Set beside Klinenberg's and Mattern's account of the library as social infrastructure (Klinenberg 2018; Mattern 2014), these let the paper treat a library's "public-ness" not as its existence but as the chain of conditions set out above — disclosure, reach, entry, governance, civic intent — and ask, condition by condition, where the postcolonial city quietly breaks it.

3 Data and Methods

The unit of analysis is the city public-library system. For Ahmedabad, the system is the Ahmedabad Public Library / M.J. Library Network, not only the flagship M.J. Library building. For Delhi, the system is Delhi Public Library, a Union-linked public-library system governed through the Delhi Library Board and funded through the Ministry of Culture.

Ahmedabad values use the compiled 83-location library inventory, M.J. Library official disclosures, and the July 2025 AMC / M.J. / Balbhavan service list (M.J. Library 2026). Delhi values use DPL annual reports from 2009-10 to 2023-24, the current 111-row DPL service hierarchy, and the fixed-location spatial layer. Comparator values use Toronto Public Library, Singapore's National Library Board, Medellin's Sistema de Bibliotecas Publicas de Medellin, Jakarta's provincial/digital library layer, and Shenzhen's "City of Libraries" network.

The comparison keeps four rules. First, normalize by population where possible. Second, separate nominal service points from effective service capacity. Third, treat public funding as an input, not a result. Fourth, disclose proxy layers rather than turning them into final claims.

The compiled inventories, the comparator tables, and the access-and-friction analysis in this paper were built with AI-assisted scripts — Anthropic's Claude models via the Claude Code harness, Google's Gemini models via Antigravity, OpenAI's GPT models via the Codex harness, and Nous Research's Hermes and Alibaba's Qwen models via OpenRouter — run under continuous human direction, alongside ward and transit layers drawn from the Campaign's city-intelligence corpus. AI tools did not select a finding or draft an evaluative claim: every figure below was checked by a human against the cited official disclosure, annual report, or parliamentary record.

This revision (v4.0) updates the transit-siting layer against `sevent4`'s expanded transit acquisition (issue #107). Each city's actual best-available transit source was verified per mode against sevent4's own per-city `sources.json` provenance records, not against its summary `transit_coverage.json` coverage manifest alone, which was found to mislabel at least one feed as unavailable when an official layer in fact existed on disk (Chennai's suburban rail, below). Where a genuinely better feed newly exists for a mode this paper's earlier draft could not classify — most consequentially, Chennai Smart City Limited's own official Sub Urban Rail inventory (which subsumes MRTS), Kolkata's suburban rail, Metro, and regulated private-bus layers, Hyderabad's official MMTS suburban rail, and Delhi's official DMRC static GTFS (262 named stations, replacing an OpenStreetMap extract) — the affected city's transit-siting figure and text are rebuilt against it, closing gaps the 2026-07-03 draft named explicitly as understating rapid-transit reach. The Delhi DMRC layer is read directly from sevent4's acquisition path (`data/cities/delhi/layers/`) rather than its public console path, because the acquiring recipe deliberately does not auto-register newly built layers into the live console pending a maintainer's decision on whether they supersede an existing one; this paper does not wait on that promotion. Where a newly constructed layer is *not* a strict improvement on what a map already used — Bengaluru's Metro sample currently omits the operational Yellow Line and its full feed remains access-gated, and Mumbai's own dedicated 148-station rapid-transit harvest outperforms sevent4's newer constructed layers despite their higher raw station count — the more complete existing layer is kept, and the paper says so at the point of use rather than silently swapping in a thinner one. Library inventories, ward geometries, and the deprivation and caste cross-tabulations are unchanged from v3.0.0; only the transit layer and the text and figures that depend on it move.

4 Ahmedabad: Municipal Network, Weak Use Conversion

The compiled Ahmedabad evidence set currently has 83 mapped library locations. Official M.J. Library annual statistics give a usable 2015-16 to 2025-26 time series.

Latest Ahmedabad values:

Field	Value	Source / scope
Service points	83	Compiled location inventory
Registered users including Gyanvihar	26,834	2025-26
Physical loans / circulation	96,491	2025-26
Collection total	811,093	2025-26
Foreign visitor / gateway exposure proxy	2.274 million	Gujarat foreign tourist visits, 2024; used as Ahmedabad gateway proxy
Branches with seating capacity disclosed	0 / 83	Public evidence reviewed
Branches with opening hours disclosed	65 official service rows	July 2025 AMC / M.J. / Balbhavan list; reconciliation to the 83-location inventory pending
Branches with branch collection size disclosed	0 / 83	Public evidence reviewed
Branches with collection types disclosed	0 / 83	Public evidence reviewed

Ahmedabad therefore looks spatially dense but service-thin in the public evidence. With a resident denominator of about 7.08 million, 83 service points is about 11.7 service points per million people. But registered users are only about 0.38 percent of residents, and physical loans are about 0.014 loans per resident per year.

The annual series also shows a weakening use profile. Circulation was over 200,000 in 2016-17 and 2017-18, fell to 89,846 in 2021-22, and is 96,491 in 2025-26. The collection continues to grow, but disclosed use does not show a corresponding service expansion.

But the weakness of the numbers should not be mistaken for an absence of commitment, and here Ahmedabad is best read alongside Chennai (Section 8) rather than only as a case of hollowing. Like Chennai's, this is a *municipal* network run off an official register — the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation operates the Sheth M.J. Library and its branch and Balbhavan libraries directly, and the location and service lists used here are AMC's own, not a crowd-sourced approximation. What Ahmedabad does *not* have is Chennai's funding law. Gujarat did enact a Public Libraries Act (No. 25 of 2001), but — unlike the Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, and Telangana statutes — it carries **no operative library cess**: there is no ring-fenced surcharge on property tax, and the libraries are sustained from ordinary municipal and state budget lines. On the paper's own computation from AMC budget data, that support runs to only low single-digit rupees per resident per year — an order of magnitude the reader should treat as an author's estimate, not an audited figure, since the underlying budget-line-to-population computation is ours and not externally corroborated. The point cuts two ways. It confirms the thinness the use figures show — a system funded at single-digit rupees per head cannot staff, stock, and open branches the way a cess-funded network can. But it also means that whatever network Ahmedabad does run, it runs on municipal will and institutional legacy alone, with none of the statutory funding scaffolding Chennai enjoys — a commitment that deserves to be named as such, and a precarious one, because a network carried by legacy rather than by law is the easiest kind to let lapse.

4.1 Administrative Gatekeeping: Residency, Aadhaar, Guarantors, and Mobile OTP

The low membership count — about 0.38 percent of the city population — is not only a sign of weak public interest. Administrative gatekeeping shapes it too. The M.J. Library site states a broad eligibility rule: all residents of Ahmedabad city can become members. But the operational requirements are stated inconsistently across the same official site. One membership section says applicants need a photograph, Aadhaar card, and guarantor name and signature. An older rules block accepts a wider set of proof for residence and photo identity: ration card, licence, passport, voting card, or Aadhaar. The current online membership form narrows the KYC dropdown to Aadhaar card, driving licence, or voter ID. Digital library registration, meanwhile, depends on a valid mobile number and OTP.

The contradiction is therefore not resident versus non-resident. It is between a broad resident-facing public-library promise and a much narrower implementation layer. If Ahmedabad residence is the eligibility test, then residence should be verifiable through multiple ordinary proofs, and Aadhaar should not become the default gate. A library can reasonably ask for stronger proof before lending books outside the building. But reading-room access, reference use, events, and basic digital discovery should not require a biometric-adjacent identity document, a personal mobile number, or a socially powerful guarantor.

These requirements create predictable barriers:

- **Migrants, renters, students, and informal workers** may live in Ahmedabad but lack documents showing an Ahmedabad address, especially if their Aadhaar or voter record is tied to a village, previous rental, hostel, employer address, or family home.
- **Women, children, older people, disabled users, and low-income users** may not control their own identity documents, phone number, scanned files, or online payment channel. The mobile-OTP model assumes individual device access that many households do not provide equally.
- **Unhoused residents and people in informal settlements** are least likely to satisfy address-proof and guarantor expectations, even though public libraries are most valuable when they operate as low-cost, low-barrier civic infrastructure.
- **Privacy-conscious readers** face a different barrier: library use becomes tied to KYC documents, phone numbers, OTP trails, usage data, and potentially analytics sharing. That can chill use, especially for students, activists, job seekers, and readers pursuing sensitive information.
- **Users who only need non-lending access** face disproportionate burden if the same proof regime is applied to reading rooms, reference material, public events, or digital browsing. Borrowing risk and in-library use are different risk categories and should not be governed by the same proof burden.

The access design principle should be proportionality. Borrowing books may justify address verification and loss recovery rules. It does not justify making Aadhaar, mobile OTP, or guarantor networks the practical threshold for participating in a municipal public library.

Governance remains partly visible and partly opaque. The live M.J. Library content still names a Library Committee / board-facing roster: Shrimati Pratibhaben Rakeshkumar Jain as Mayor of Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation and Chairman; Shri Devang Jitendrabhai Dani as Chairman, Library Standing Committee; Dr. Sujay J. Mehta as a member of the Sheth M.J. Library management committee/board and Chairman, School Board, Ahmedabad; Shree Faljibhai G. Patel and Shree Jigneshkumar U. Pandya as scholar members of that management committee/board; Shri N. N. Dave (IAS) as Deputy Municipal Commissioner (Library); and Shri Malav Nawab as Municipal Chief Auditor. But AMC's official mayor incumbency table now lists Shri Hitesh Kantilal Barot as Mayor from 26 May 2026 to 26 May 2031, and lists Pratibhaben Jain's mayoral term as 11 September 2023 to 9 March 2026. The M.J. page therefore appears unsynchronised with current AMC incumbency. Separately, AMC's 2026 Standing Committee PDF lists a general Standing Committee appointed from 26 May 2026, with a PDF title/metadata term ending 25 November 2028; that committee is chaired by Kamleshbhai Maheshchandra Patel, not Devang Dani. A separate M.J. site cluster names Dr Bipin J Modi as Librarian, Mr. YogeshKumar J Patel as Assistant Librarian, Shri Prashant Pandya as Municipal Director, and Mr. Deepak Trivedi as I/C Deputy Municipal Commissioner (Library). The rules also give the librarian some first-instance decision powers and give the library management committee appeal/rule-changing powers. What is still missing is the formal by-laws or constitution, a confirmed current library-board roster, library-specific committee appointment dates, term lengths, delegation of powers, and professional qualifications.

5 Delhi: Central System, Local Service Problem

Delhi Public Library is not the same kind of object as Ahmedabad's municipal library network. DPL is tied to the Delhi Library Board and Union Ministry of Culture funding. Its governance should therefore be read as a capital-city special case: a library system serving local residents, but not simply controlled through ordinary municipal government.

The current Delhi service hierarchy distinguishes fixed libraries from mobile service points. The compiled inventory has 111 located DPL rows. That does not mean 111 equivalent library buildings. The hierarchy includes headquarters, zonal libraries, branch libraries, sub-branch libraries, a Braille library, a community library, and scheduled mobile-library stops.

Current Delhi hierarchy facts:

Field	Value
Total working DPL locations	111
Fixed physical locations	35
Mobile service points	76
Headquarters	1
Zonal libraries	4
Branch libraries	8
Special fixed library	1
Sub-branch libraries	20
Community library	1
Located rows	111 / 111

For the purposes of this paper, the important distinction is not only how many DPL rows exist, but what kind of service they represent. A mobile stop, a sub-branch, a zonal library, and headquarters do not offer the same service capacity, even if they all appear in a single institutional inventory.

The DPL annual-report time series runs from 2009-10 to 2023-24 for members, issues, reading-room attendance, collection, accessions, and expenditure. The 2023-24 values are:

Field	Value	Year
Registered members	110,534	2023-24
Physical loans / issues	274,751	2023-24
Reading-room attendance proxy	335,270	2023-24
Collection total	1,527,531	2023-24
Total expenditure	INR 328,986,673	2023-24
Foreign tourist visits	1.83 million	Delhi, 2023

Delhi's problem is not only missing branches. It is a decline in use intensity. DPL issues were 1,169,734 in 2010-11 and 1,138,767 in 2012-13. By 2023-24 they were 274,751. Registered members peaked at 189,235 in 2019-20 and were 110,534 in 2023-24. The collection remains large, but circulation has collapsed.

5.1 Administrative Gatekeeping: The Attestation-or-Deposit Gate

Delhi gates access just as severely. DPL accepts a broader range of residency documents than Ahmedabad — utility bills, bank passbooks — but filters enrolment through social and financial capital:

- **The Attestation Requirement**: To obtain a standard membership (costing INR 100), the application form must be attested by a "responsible person"—defined strictly as a Gazetted Officer, school principal, doctor, lawyer, bank manager, or Residents Welfare Association (RWA) president.
- **The Financial Substitution (INR 3,000 Deposit)**: If an applicant lacks the social capital to obtain attestation from these elite professionals, they must alternatively pay a refundable security deposit of INR 3,000.
- **Impact**: For a working-class resident, migrant student, or informal settlement dweller, this dual-gate acts as an exclusionary filter. They must either navigate an elite social patronage network to secure a signature, or lock up a week's or fortnight's worth of wages in a library deposit. This structural gatekeeping directly correlates with the steep decline in active DPL membership over the last decade.

5.2 Staffing as a Time Series

The evidence set already had the 2023-24 vacancy count. The staffing table below extends that into a time series from the available annual-report PDFs.

Year	Sanctioned posts	Filled posts	Vacant posts	Vacancy rate	Notes
2017-18	290	204	86	29.7%	Total derived from annual report text.
2018-19	282	258	24	8.5%	Best recent low vacancy point.
2019-20	282	221	61	21.6%	Vacancy rising before the pandemic year.
2020-21	NA	NA	NA	NA	PDF archived, OCR required.
2021-22	274	173	101	36.9%	68 professional and 33 ministerial vacancies.
2022-23	274	151	123	44.9%	86 professional and 37 ministerial vacancies.
2023-24	274	138	136	49.6%	102 professional and 34 ministerial vacancies.

The staffing story is stark. DPL moves from 24 vacancies in 2018-19 to 136 vacancies in 2023-24. Professional vacancies rise to 102 by 2023-24. The annual report itself says day-to-day tasks are being carried out by contract employees because of staff shortage. This matters for IFLA because a service point without staff capacity is not equivalent to a functioning library.

The 2020-21 PDF is archived, but the usable staffing table has not yet been recovered. The staffing series is therefore continuous for 2017-18 to 2019-20 and 2021-22 to 2023-24, with a documented gap for 2020-21.

5.3 Parliamentary Record: Union Control, State-Subject Deflection

The parliamentary record sharpens the Delhi case because it shows the contradiction inside the Union's own account of public libraries. DPL is not merely a Delhi local body in central territory. In Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 4193, answered on 4 April 2018, the Ministry of Culture listed Delhi Public Library as one of six public libraries under its administrative control, along with the National Library, Central Reference Library, Central Secretariat Library, Khuda Bakhsh Oriental Public Library, and Rampur Raza Library.[1] An older Rajya Sabha answer places DPL inside a second national function: under the Delivery of Books Act, 1954, the four depository libraries were the National Library, Calcutta; Delhi Public Library, Delhi; State Central Library, Mumbai; and Connemara Public Library, Chennai.[2]

Against that direct Union role, the Ministry's later answers repeatedly move responsibility away from the Centre. On 7 April 2022, asked whether public libraries had been neglected and what the Ministry was doing to modify the system for ICT, the answer began by saying that library is a State subject and public libraries function under State or Union Territory authorities; only then did it add that five libraries, including DPL, were funded by the Ministry of Culture.[3] On 4 August 2022, a question on funds, infrastructure, and digitisation received the same State-subject formula, followed by a limited description of NML and RRRLF assistance.[4] On 22 December 2022, a question that asked directly for library budget allocations and vacant posts in Union-funded national libraries got a vacancy non-answer — vacancies arise in the regular course and are filled "as and when" they arise — before the answer again moved public-library building and development to State or Union Territory control.[5]

The pattern continues into 2024 and 2025. Questions on the National Mission on Libraries in August and December 2024 again start from the State-subject position, even while describing a Union scheme that assists one State Central Library and one District Library in each State or Union Territory and six Ministry-identified libraries.[6] In March 2025, when asked for data on public libraries in the country, the Ministry answered that libraries come under the State list and that no such data is maintained; the same answer then reported NML and RRRLF financial assistance figures.[7] The result is a stable administrative grammar: the Union can fund, administer, and modernise selected libraries, including DPL, but when asked for system accountability it retreats to the federal location of "libraries" in the State list.

That grammar matters for Delhi. DPL's annual reports show circulation collapse and a near-half staffing vacancy. Parliament shows how those facts become administratively deniable. The Ministry can acknowledge Union-funded libraries, name DPL as one of them, and publish budget lines; but the broader public-library obligation is repeatedly displaced onto States and Union Territories. In 2018, the Ministry told Parliament that only nineteen states had library legislation, and again used the State-subject position to frame central action as financial assistance through RRRLF rather than an enforceable public-library service standard.[8] The disclosure failure in Delhi is therefore not only a missing table in an annual report. It is an accountability structure: enough centrality to control and fund DPL, enough federal deflection to avoid a national public-service obligation.

[1] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 4193, 4 April 2018, Ministry of Culture.
[2] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 2059, 3 July 1998, Ministry of Human Resource Development.
[3] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 4014, 7 April 2022, Ministry of Culture.
[4] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 2087, 4 August 2022, Ministry of Culture.
[5] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 1771, 22 December 2022, Ministry of Culture.
[6] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Questions 1142, 1 August 2024; 1137 and 1141, 5 December 2024, Ministry of Culture.
[7] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 3062, 27 March 2025, Ministry of Culture.
[8] Rajya Sabha Unstarred Question 4190, 4 April 2018, Ministry of Culture.

6 Bengaluru: The Cess That Is Collected and Never Arrives

Bengaluru is the control case for a claim the first two cities cannot test. Ahmedabad and Delhi are underfunded systems, so their hollowing can always be attributed to scarcity. Karnataka removes that alibi. It is one of six states with an operative library cess, a 6 per cent surcharge on property tax under the Karnataka Public Libraries Act, 1965, and its capital should therefore show whether a dedicated funding instrument delivers reach. The unit here is the city public-library system run by the Karnataka Department of Public Libraries, whose City Central Library network is organised into five zones across the erstwhile 198 BBMP wards.

Two measurement cautions frame every number below. First, the ward vintage. Bengaluru's wards were re-cut by the Greater Bengaluru Governance Act, 2024: the old 198 BBMP wards were reorganised into 369 wards across five corporations, notified on 19 November 2025. The access surface here uses that current GBA 369-ward frame, with population, Scheduled Caste, and Scheduled Tribe counts taken from the Census-derived attributes carried on the ward layer. Second, the library inventory, and here Bengaluru delivers a disclosure finding in its own right. Unlike Ahmedabad's compiled 83-location list and Delhi's 111-row service hierarchy, no coordinate-complete public inventory of Bengaluru's libraries was available for this pass. The city library count is itself contested: the Department reports about 1,032 libraries statewide under the 1965 Act, but for Bengaluru its own sources give 458 government-run libraries (Department website), about 200 public libraries across five zones once Gram Panchayat and Vachanalaya reading rooms are included, 115 on one departmental map, and 80 within 20 km of the State Central Library. The firm skeleton is a State Central Library at Cubbon Park plus five zonal City Central Libraries, with the Central zone alone listing 29 branch libraries, implying a citywide network in the hundreds. The only open geospatial layer, OpenStreetMap amenity=library, holds 73 points and conflates the public network with university, commercial, and institutional libraries; between about 12 (strictly government-tagged) and 18 (a broader public-keyword net) are identifiably public, so open data captures under a tenth of even the lowest official figure. We geocoded the six flagship apex and zonal libraries from the department's own roster and tested whether open data captures them: only two fall within 350 m of a mapped OSM library, the East zone library at R.T. Nagar and the West zone library at Vijayanagar. The State Central Library and the South, Central, and North zone libraries are not identifiably mapped. Every access statistic below is therefore reported twice, over the full 73-point mapped surface and over the 18-point public subset, with the true public network lying above the public-subset figures. That the state runs a network of more than a hundred libraries which open data renders as eighteen points, missing even the State Central Library, is not a data-cleaning nuisance. It is the paper's disclosure thesis in its starkest form: in the one state whose law funds libraries, the count of libraries is itself not legible from outside.

On the full mapped surface, 153 of 369 ward centroids fall within a 1.2 km straight-line walk of a library, the population-weighted median ward walk time is 17 minutes, and about 80 per cent of residents are within a 30-minute walk. On the 18-point public subset the surface collapses: 67 of 369 wards within 1.2 km, a median of 33 minutes, and under half the population within a 30-minute walk. The worst-served wards on the mapped surface are the outer northwest and south, Andrahalli at a 79-minute walk, Bagalagunte 76, Dodda Bidarakallu 71, Gottigere 70, Manjunatha Nagar 68, and Anjanapura 63.

Crossing access against caste share on the same ward frame yields a real but modest gradient. City-wide

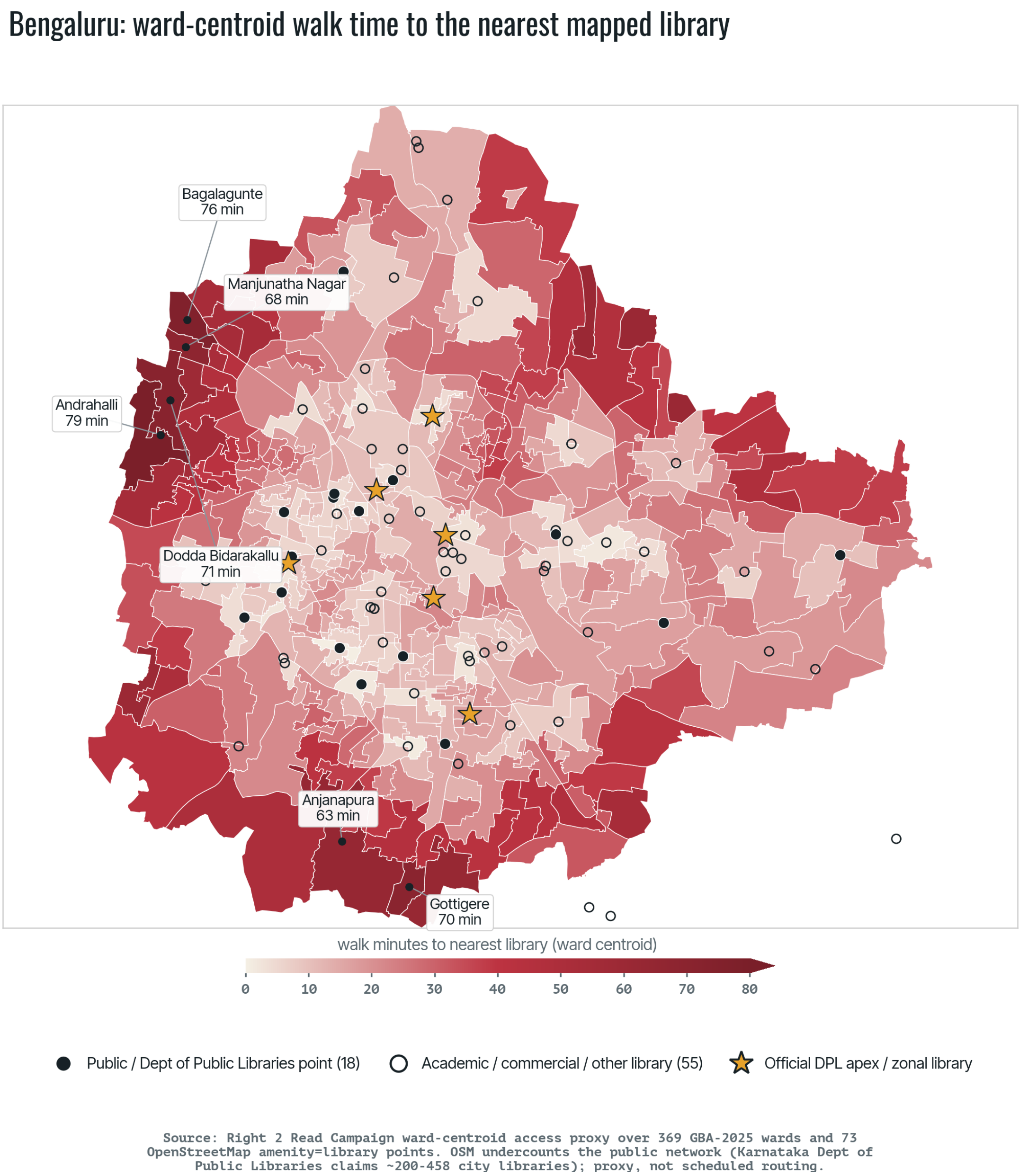


Figure 1: Bengaluru access proxy. Straight-line distance from each of the 369 GBA-2025 ward centroids to the nearest of 73 mapped libraries; filled dots are the 18 public or Department of Public Libraries points, hollow dots academic, commercial, and institutional libraries. Proxy, not a street-network travel-time model.

the Scheduled-Caste and Scheduled-Tribe share is 13.2 per cent. The 216 wards beyond a 1.2 km walk hold 4.87 million residents; the 120 of them that are also above the median SC and ST share hold 2.62 million. Mean SC and ST share is 14.2 per cent in the far wards against 12.2 per cent in the near wards. The caste geography of exclusion is present, but it is shallower than Ahmedabad's double-locked quadrant, and it should not be overstated on Census-apportioned ward attributes.

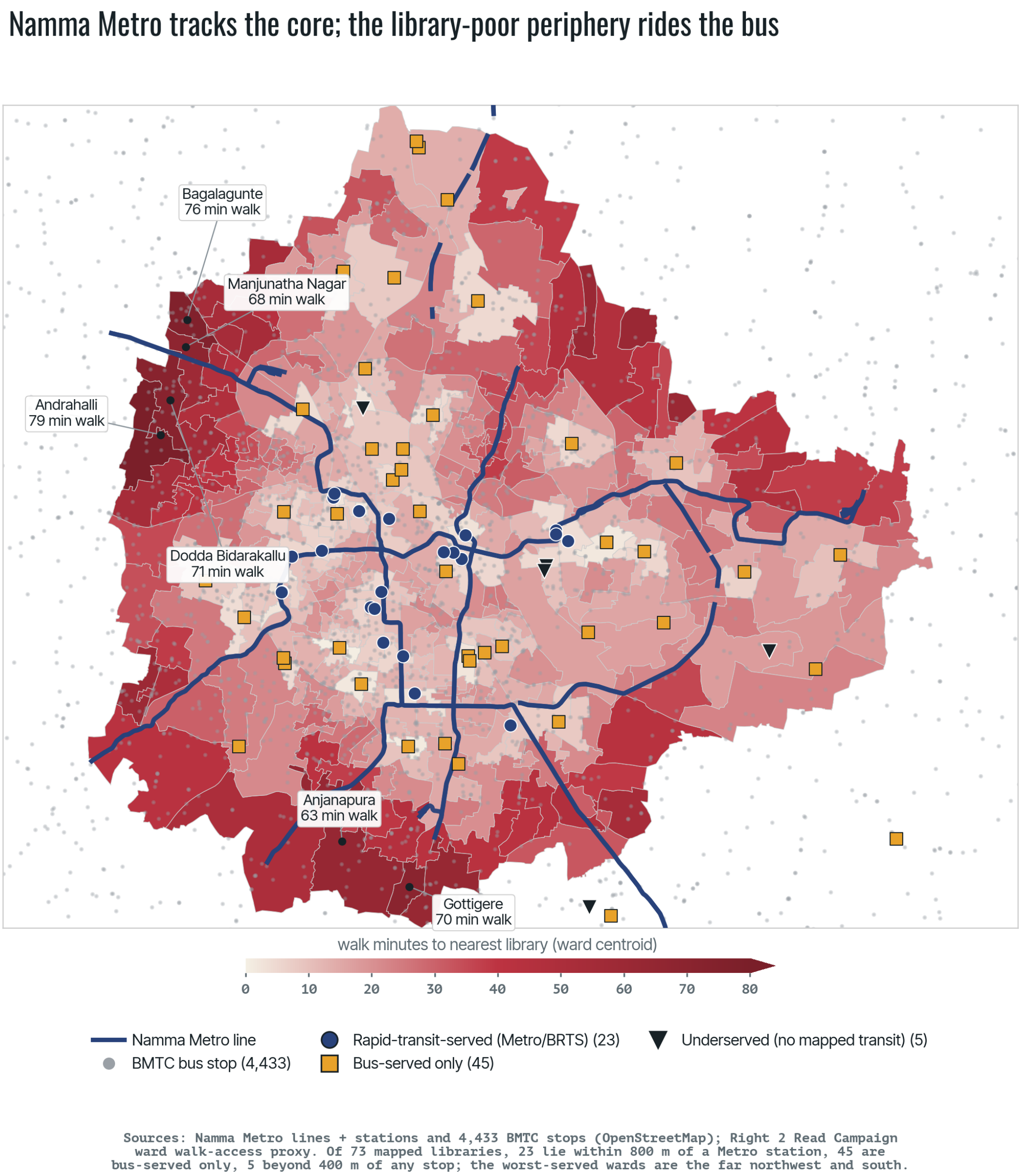


Figure 2: Bengaluru transit siting. The 73 mapped libraries classified by transit access over the same walk-time surface: blue circles are rapid-transit-served (within 800 m of a Namma Metro station), gold squares bus-served only (within 400 m of a BMTC stop), black triangles underserved. 23 are rapid-transit-served, 45 bus-served only, and 5 beyond 400 m of any mapped stop; the library-poor northwest and south periphery rides the bus, not the Metro. Bus siting now uses sevent4's official BMTC stop layer (4,433 stops, issue #107, up from a 3,378-point OSM extract); Metro still uses the fuller of the two available layers (89 stations), since sevent4's newly constructed Metro sample explicitly omits the operational Yellow Line.

On siting, 9 of the 73 mapped libraries lie within 500 m of a Namma Metro station and 65 within

500 m of a BMTC bus stop; on the public subset, 7 of 18 are near a Metro station and all 18 near a bus stop. As in Delhi, the bus reaches the libraries and the Metro, the network the city has spent a decade extending toward its office and IT core, mostly does not. The suggestion the data raises — not a verdict it settles — is that the rapid-transit investment has tracked the accumulation geography more closely than the reading geography.

The decisive Bengaluru finding is fiscal, and it inverts the funding hypothesis. The cess exists and is even collected, but it does not reach the libraries. The Karnataka Public Libraries Act entitles libraries to 6 per cent of the property tax collected by the urban local body. Yet BBMP did not release that cess to the Department of Public Libraries for over six years: by early 2020 the arrears had crossed Rs 400 crore, in a year the corporation booked a record Rs 2,510 crore in property tax, and by more recent reporting the withheld amount has climbed toward Rs 700 crore against a token Rs 14 crore released.[9] An estimated 70 to 80 per cent of library staff are contract workers paid roughly Rs 6,500 a month. The membership counter, by contrast, is comparatively cheap, a refundable lifetime card of Rs 100 to 200, so Bengaluru's exclusion is not principally administered at the desk. It is administered upstream, by a funding instrument that is levied and then withheld, and by a network so poorly disclosed that neither its true size nor its per-branch service can be audited from the outside. This is not the hollowing-by-neglect of Ahmedabad and Delhi. It is a funded mechanism starved at the source by municipal non-remittance. Karnataka's cess does not falsify the paper's thesis. It sharpens it: even where the state has legislated a dedicated stream for reading, the money can be collected, retained, and spent on everything the showcase city photographs, while the library recedes as a service and disappears as a number.

7 Hyderabad: The Cess Collected and Withheld

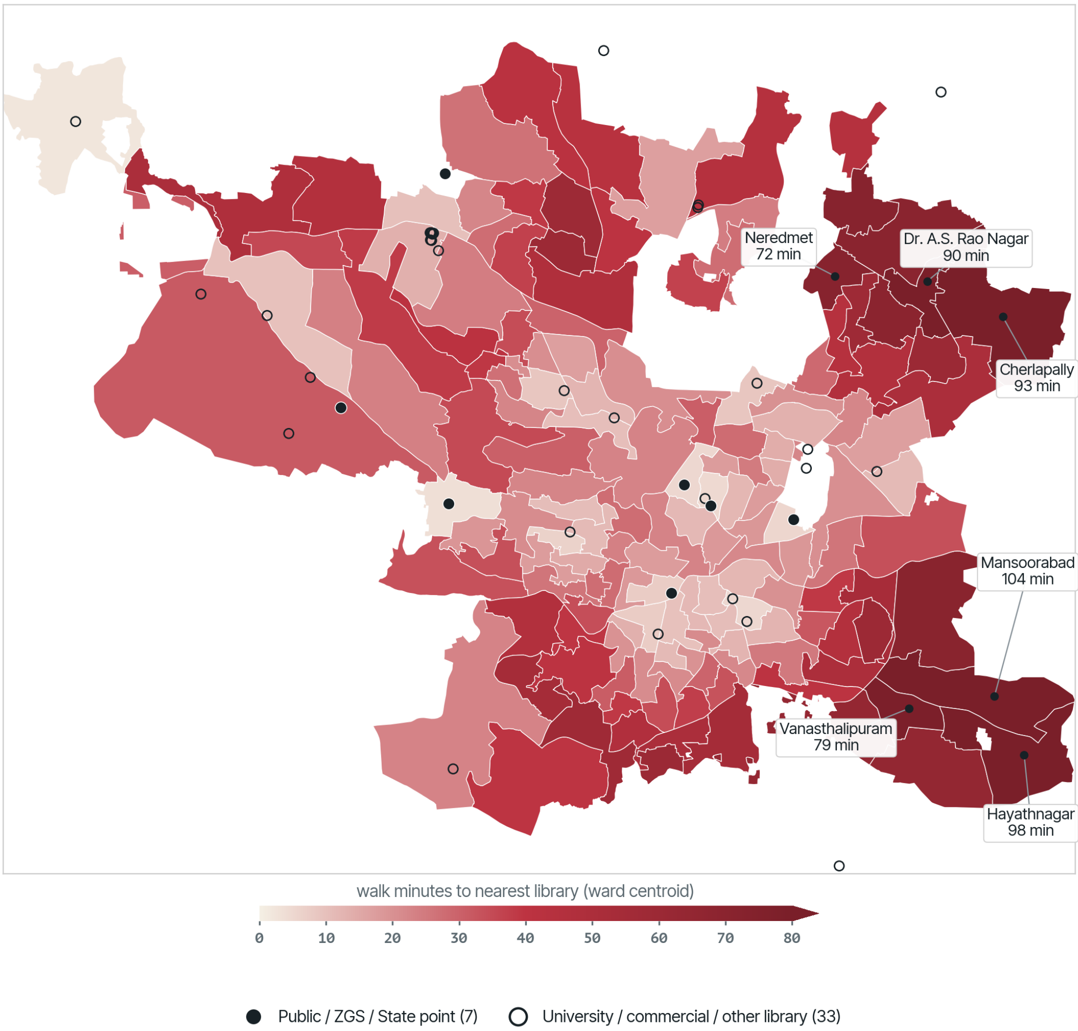
Hyderabad extends the same access diagnostic to a third city and to the case where the disclosure gap is widest. The open location inventory is thin: the city's open data records 40 points tagged as libraries, and only seven of these are identifiable as public, State, or Zilla Grandhalaya Samstha libraries, the rest being university, corporate, and commercial reading rooms. The public network is far larger than the mapped surface. The Hyderabad City Grandhalaya Samstha alone maintains at least 86 public libraries (Deccan Chronicle, 3 April 2026), so the seven public points in open data capture under a tenth of the public network. The access proxy is therefore run twice, once on all 40 mapped points and once on the seven identifiable-public points, and both are reported. The ward frame is the GHMC 150-ward structure of 2007; a fresh delimitation to 300 wards was notified in December 2025 but is not yet reflected in the open ward layer, and the layer carries no per-ward population, so the percentiles below are unweighted ward-count distributions rather than a population-weighted audit.

On this frame, only 34 of the 150 ward centroids fall within a 1.2 km walk of any of the 40 mapped library points, and the median ward-centroid walk is about 27 minutes. Restricting to the seven identifiable-public points, only 8 of 150 wards fall inside the same 1.2 km band and the median walk rises to about 52 minutes. The worst-served wards are the eastern and north-eastern periphery absorbed

[9] Citizen Matters, "Bengaluru's library system: long way to go," 8 Feb 2020, citizenmatters.in/bengaluru-public-libraries-funding-cess-legislation-42532 (6% cess; BBMP "has not released the library cess… in over six years"; "owed amount has crossed Rs 400 crore"; "record Rs 2510 crore in property tax"). Corroborated by The Softcopy, "Neglected spaces: Bangalore's public libraries seek overdue funds," 2023, and Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, on the withheld cess climbing toward Rs 700 crore. Membership terms (lifetime Rs 100-200, refundable) and the 70-80% contract-staffing estimate from the Citizen Matters reporting.

in the 2007 expansion: Mansoorabad at roughly 104 walking minutes from the nearest mapped library, Hayathnagar at 98, and Cherlapally at 93, with Dr. A.S. Rao Nagar, Vanasthalipuram, Neredmet, Nagole, and Kapra close behind. This is a straight-line ward-centroid proxy, not a street-network travel-time model, and it triages rather than settles the question.

Hyderabad: ward-centroid walk time to the nearest mapped library



Source: Right 2 Read Campaign ward-centroid access proxy over 150 GHMC wards and 40 OpenStreetMap amenity=library points. OSM undercounts the public network (Telangana Dept of Public Libraries / Zilla Grandhalaya Samstha run far more); distance surface UNWEIGHTED (no per-ward population); proxy, not routing.

Figure 3: Hyderabad: distance from each of the 150 GHMC ward centroids to the nearest of 40 mapped library points, with the seven identifiable-public points drawn as filled markers. The core is served; the eastern periphery annexed in 2007 (Mansoorabad, Hayathnagar, Cherlapally) lies an hour or more on foot from any mapped library.

Siting against the rapid network repeats the Ahmedabad finding. Hyderabad's Metro is three elevated corridors run as a Larsen and Toubro public-private concession, and two of its three termini, LB Nagar on the Red Line and Nagole on the Blue Line, sit in the same library-poor eastern periphery. Against sevent4's official Metro layer (705 stops, up from a 69-point extract this figure used before), 11 of the 40 mapped libraries, and one of the seven identifiable-public points, lie within 500 m of a Metro station, while 27 of 40 are within 500 m of a bus stop. The pattern this raises — worth marking rather than pronouncing on — is that the city's most expensive transit asset reaches into some of the same peripheral wards it has left without a mapped public reading room: the periphery, on this evidence, is nearer the train than the library, echoing Ahmedabad, while Delhi shows the mirror case of a Metro that runs past the libraries it has. The reading is only suggestive, and the bus layer's sparseness (below) cautions against pressing it hard.

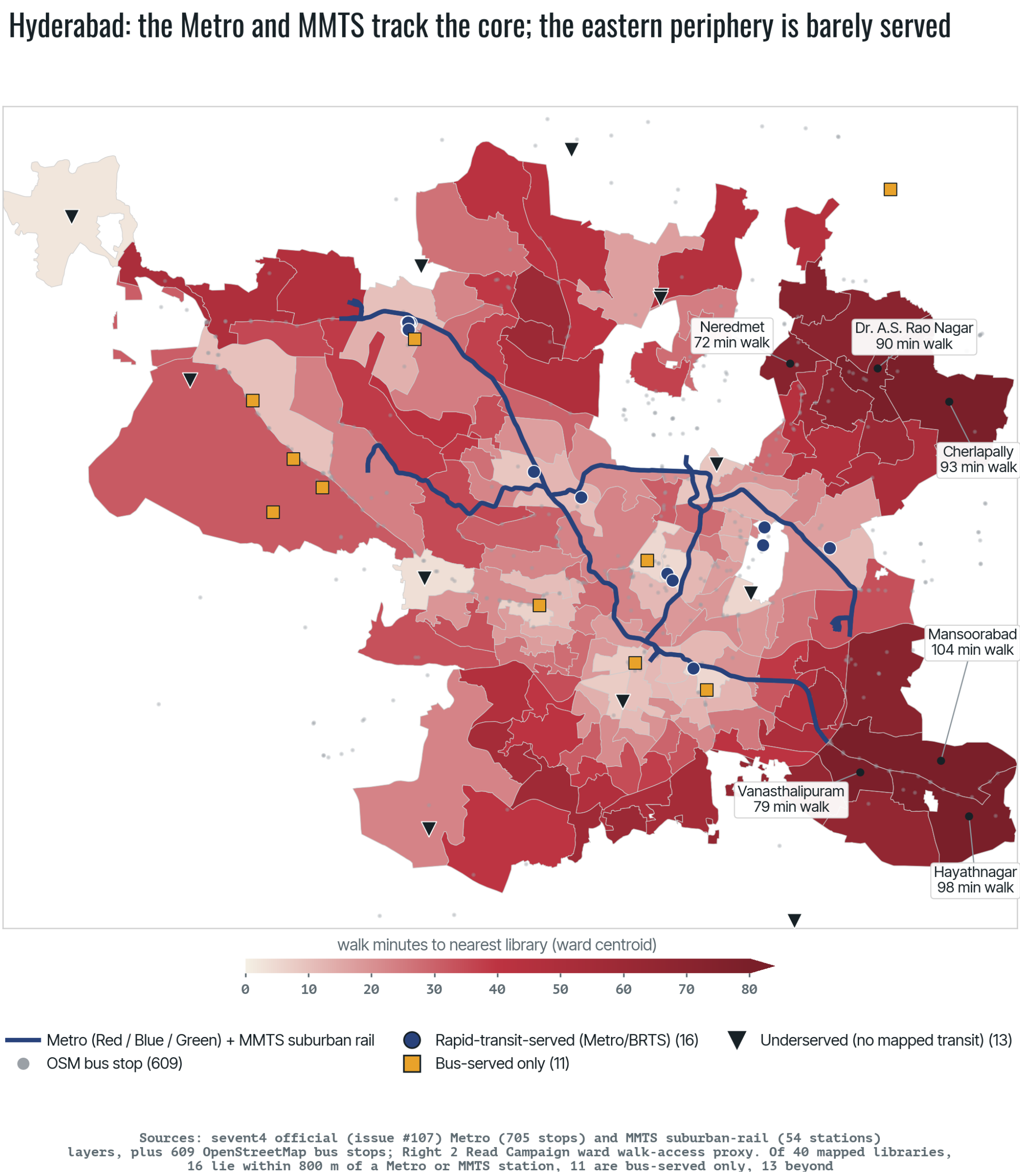


Figure 4: Hyderabad's 40 mapped libraries classified by transit access over the same walk-time surface: blue circles are rapid-transit-served (within 800 m of a Metro or MMTS suburban-rail station), gold squares bus-served only (within 400 m of one of 609 mapped bus stops), black triangles underserved. 16 are rapid-transit-served, 11 bus-served only, and 13 beyond 400 m of any mapped stop; the eastern periphery annexed in 2007 sits off both networks. Metro and MMTS now use sevent4's official (issue #107) layers — 705 Metro stops and 54 MMTS stations, replacing a 69-point Metro extract and adding MMTS for the first time — but the near-identical rapid count shows the periphery gap is about geography, not station-count granularity. The bus layer is still a sparse 609-stop OpenStreetMap extract (TSRTC does not publish an open GTFS feed), so the underserved count remains an upper bound.

A caste reading of this surface cannot be run at ward level, because the open ward layer carries no

Scheduled-Caste or Scheduled-Tribe share and Telangana does not publish ward-level caste counts. A coarse proxy using SC-reserved assembly constituencies is uninformative here: the only SC-reserved constituency falling inside the GHMC core, Secunderabad Cantonment, is central and comparatively well served, so the reserved-seat proxy shows no periphery gradient. The caste geography of Hyderabad's library access is thus a measured gap in this study rather than a finding, and it is named as such: the distance surface is real, but the ward-level caste cross that Ahmedabad's slum-census data allowed is not yet possible for Hyderabad without primary data.

7.1 The cess spine - Telangana next to Karnataka

Hyderabad is the cleanest instance of the mechanism this paper is built around: not a poor state that cannot afford libraries, but a rich tax that is collected and then not passed on. The Telangana Public Libraries Act of 1960, section 20, levies a library cess as a surcharge on property tax, which the Hyderabad City Grandhalaya Samstha is entitled to at up to eight paise in the rupee, and directs that the proceeds be paid to the Samstha. In practice the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation collects the surcharge and withholds it. By April 2026 the arrears owed to the Hyderabad City Grandhalaya Samstha stood at about Rs 175 crore, part of Rs 302.49 crore withheld across the state's urban local bodies, accumulated over roughly fifteen years, with the corporation conceding only a token Rs 35 lakh a month over the prior two years (Deccan Chronicle, 3 April 2026). The consequence is a network kept legally alive and financially starved: 86-plus city libraries maintained on the trickle, a thousand planned e-libraries unbuilt, and upgrade works at the State Central Library at Afzalgunj left incomplete.

This is the Karnataka pattern with a Telangana face. In Bengaluru the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike collected the Karnataka library cess and withheld an estimated Rs 400 to 700 crore from the library authority over six years and more; in Hyderabad the GHMC has done the same with about Rs 175 crore over some fifteen years. Two states, two statutes from the same mid-century library-movement moment, two municipal corporations that treat a ring-fenced reading tax as general revenue to be sat on. The gate at the free library, in this third city, is not primarily the counter clerk. It is the municipal treasury that pockets the cess and lets the reading room decay, then presents the surviving buildings as proof the service still exists.

8 Chennai: The Madras Model — Legislation, a Cess, and a Network You Can Actually See

Chennai is the case that tests the paper's own thesis from the other side. Every city so far has failed a condition of public-ness; Chennai is where the Indian public library comes closest to meeting them, and the reason is historical. Tamil Nadu's public library system rests on the **Tamil Nadu (Madras) Public Libraries Act, 1948** — India's *first* public-library statute, drafted through the Madras Library Association with S.R. Ranganathan as its principal architect, and the model every later state Act copied. The 1948 Act did two things the later imitators often dropped: it created a statutory **Local Library Authority** to run the network as a service, and it funded that network with a dedicated **library cess**, a surcharge on property tax (historically levied at, and commonly reported as, ten paise in the rupee) collected by the corporation and paid to the Authority. The unit here is the city public-library system run by the **Local Library Authority, Chennai** across the 200 wards and 15 zones of the Greater Chennai Corporation (the 200-ward frame in force since the October 2011 expansion, when the city grew from 176 to 426 km²).

The measurement inversion is the finding. Where Bengaluru and Hyderabad forced the paper to report access twice — once over a full OSM surface and once over the handful of identifiably public points — because open data captured under a tenth of the real network, Chennai's library layer is not OSM at all. It is the **Greater Chennai Corporation's own "Chennai Libraries" register** (published through the OpenCity civic-amenities portal): 149 geocoded points, 147 of them tagged to the authority of the Local Library Authority, Chennai, and typed as they are administered — 111 branch libraries, 18 part-time, 12 full-time, five central, a district central library, and the two state flagships, the Connemara Public Library and the Anna Centenary Library. That 149-point register is broadly consistent with the Authority's own reported size (on the order of 120–160 libraries); it is a disclosed network, not a tenth of one. In the one southern state whose library law is oldest, the count of libraries is legible from outside — the disclosure thesis, run in reverse.

To hold the register to the same spatial standard as the other cities, we re-geocoded it to point precision. The GCC/OpenCity file placed its 149 entries only at pincode or locality centroids — 81 unique coordinates — so we geocoded each branch's own street address (which the register carries) through the Google Geocoding API: **122 of the 149 resolve to point level** (address, interpolated, or feature-centre matches), the remaining 27 — mostly OCR-garbled address strings — falling back to the register's locality centroid, and no library dropped. The result is 142 distinct locations rather than 81, an address-level surface, with per-point provenance recorded. One caution survives the upgrade: the 27 fallbacks stay locality-level, so a minority of points remain coarse. And a second, deeper caution is unchanged — the register discloses *locations*; the service fields the IFLA frame expects (per-branch hours, seating, collection, staff, circulation, membership) are as absent from Chennai's public evidence as from every other city here, and remain an RTI gap.

On this address-level frame, the disclosed network reaches most of the core and thins hard at the edge the city most recently swallowed — and, reassuringly, the headline is robust to the geocoding upgrade rather than an artefact of it. **111 of the 200 GCC ward centroids fall within a 1.2 km straight-line walk** of a listed library (the same count the locality version returned); the median ward-centroid walk is about 11 minutes and roughly 73 per cent of wards lie within a 30-minute walk. But moving the branches onto their real streets *lengthens* the tail rather than shortening it: the ninetieth percentile rises to about 62 minutes, and the worst-served wards are the industrial and IT-corridor fringe annexed in 2011 — Thiruvottiyur and Manali on the northern petrochemical belt, an hour and three-quarters and nearly two hours from the nearest listed library, and Sholinganallur on the far southern OMR software corridor an hour and a half out, with Ambattur in the west close behind.

Siting against the rapid network is the one figure in this paper that changes materially between drafts, because the input transit layer itself changed. The 2026-07-03 draft classified libraries against the Metro and MTC bus only (both from the community-maintained ChennaiGTFS package), named Chennai's suburban railway and MRTS as a known gap, and reported the reach as a lower bound: 55 rapid-transit-served, 52 bus-served only, 42 beyond 400 m of any mapped stop. Chennai Smart City Limited's own open-data portal publishes an official Sub Urban Rail station inventory — corroborated by a Southern Railway press release naming the same four corridors, including MRTS — that closes this gap: it already contains every MRTS station, so no separate MRTS layer is needed. Reclassified against Metro, the official CSCL suburban rail (which subsumes MRTS), and MTC bus, **83 of the 149 register points are rapid-transit-served, 56 are bus-served only, and 10 lie beyond 400 m**

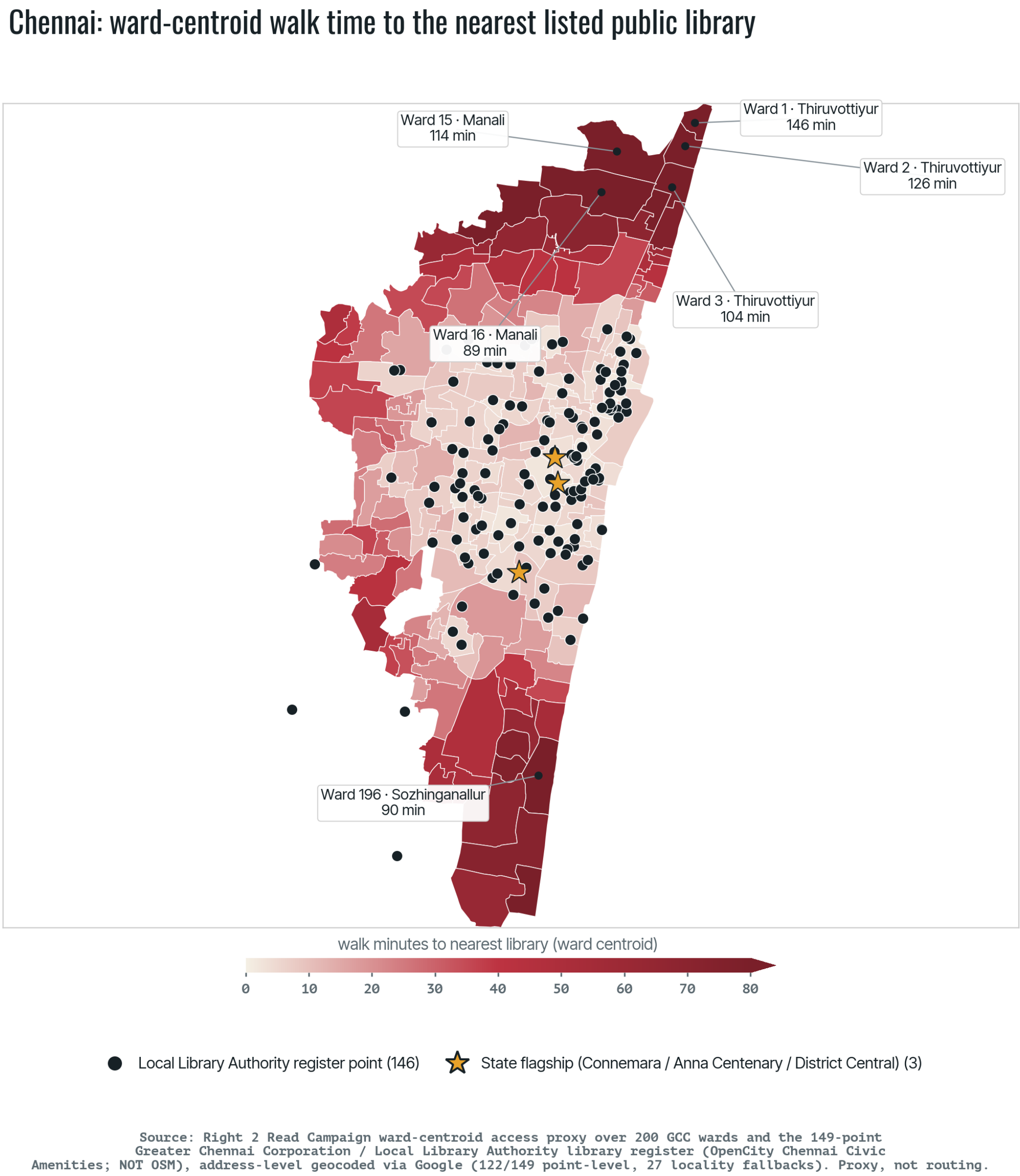


Figure 5: Chennai access proxy. Straight-line distance from each of the 200 GCC ward centroids to the nearest of the 149 points in the Greater Chennai Corporation / Local Library Authority library register; filled dots are register points, gold stars the three state flagships (Connemara, Anna Centenary, District Central). Register addresses were geocoded to point level via Google (122 of 149 point-level; 27 locality fallbacks; 142 unique coordinates), with per-point provenance recorded. A straight-line proxy, not a street-network travel-time model.

of any mapped stop — the underserved count falls by three-quarters once the suburban railway is counted, confirming that the earlier Metro-only figure understated reach exactly as flagged, and by a wide margin. Chennai's major rail mode was never the Metro: the **suburban railway**, run by Southern Railway (a zone of Indian Railways) across the metropolitan area, together with the elevated **MRTS** (Chennai's Mass Rapid Transit System, opened 1995 and also a Southern Railway line), carries far more of the working city than the two-line, forty-one-station Metro of Phase 1. The MRTS is itself in transition: the Ministry of Railways approved its transfer to, and merger with, Chennai Metro Rail Limited in 2025, coordinated through the Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority, with Southern Railway continuing to run it until the handover completes — targeted, on current reporting, for December 2027. The CSCL inventory is a 2019 snapshot cross-matched to current OSM station geometry, so some residual undercount is still possible if station membership has changed since; a separate MobilityData-derived suburban-rail extract exists but is explicitly flagged as a weaker, unofficial "schedule lead" and was not used here. What survives from the Metro-only reading is the siting pattern: the Metro traces the central and southern IT spine of the accumulation city, and the annexed industrial fringe farthest from a library still rides the bus and the suburban line rather than the Metro — a pattern worth investigating rather than a verdict on intent.

A caste reading of this surface cannot be resolved at the available resolution, and is named as a limit rather than dressed as a finding. The open GCC ward layer carries neither population nor Scheduled-Caste and Scheduled-Tribe share, so the ward-level cross that Ahmedabad's slum-census data allowed is not possible here. The only caste signal available — tagging wards by whether their Assembly Constituency is SC-reserved — is uninformative in Chennai: the two reserved constituencies in frame, Egmore (SC) and Thiru-Vi-Ka-Nagar (SC), are both central and comparatively well served (the twelve wards falling in them average a 6.6-minute walk against 24.4 minutes elsewhere), so the reserved-seat proxy shows no periphery gradient. What Chennai demonstrates is narrower and more useful than a caste map: that an Indian city *can* legislate a public-library authority, fund it through a ring-fenced cess, and disclose its network as a register precise enough to geocode — and that even where all three hold, the reading commons still recedes at the annexed edge, and the service behind the locations still goes unreported. Connemara, opened in 1896 and one of the four National Depository Libraries under the Delivery of Books Act, 1954, and the Anna Centenary Library, opened in 2010, anchor a system that is real; the question Chennai leaves is whether the periphery and the reading room inside each branch are planned with the same seriousness as the flagship.

Chennai is, then, the Madras pole of the paper's organizing axis — the reading commons funded by a dedicated, buoyant public revenue and, because it is funded, disclosed. It anchors one corner of a contrast the built-out cases now make legible, each turning on the relationship between the law, the money, and the record. In Chennai the network is funded *by statute* — the 1948 Act's Local Library Authority and its ring-fenced cess — and it works, and is disclosed, because the law funds it. Ahmedabad (Section 4) is the near-opposite arrangement: a municipal network sustained *despite* the absence of a funding law, on institutional legacy alone. Kolkata, next, is a large, legislated, officially catalogued network left to decay because the Act that created it dropped the one instrument — the cess — that would have paid for it. And Mumbai (Section 10), last, is the Bombay pole itself: the other founding statute, which built the same authority but chose a fixed grant over a cess from the start — the antithesis Chennai's case requires to be read against.

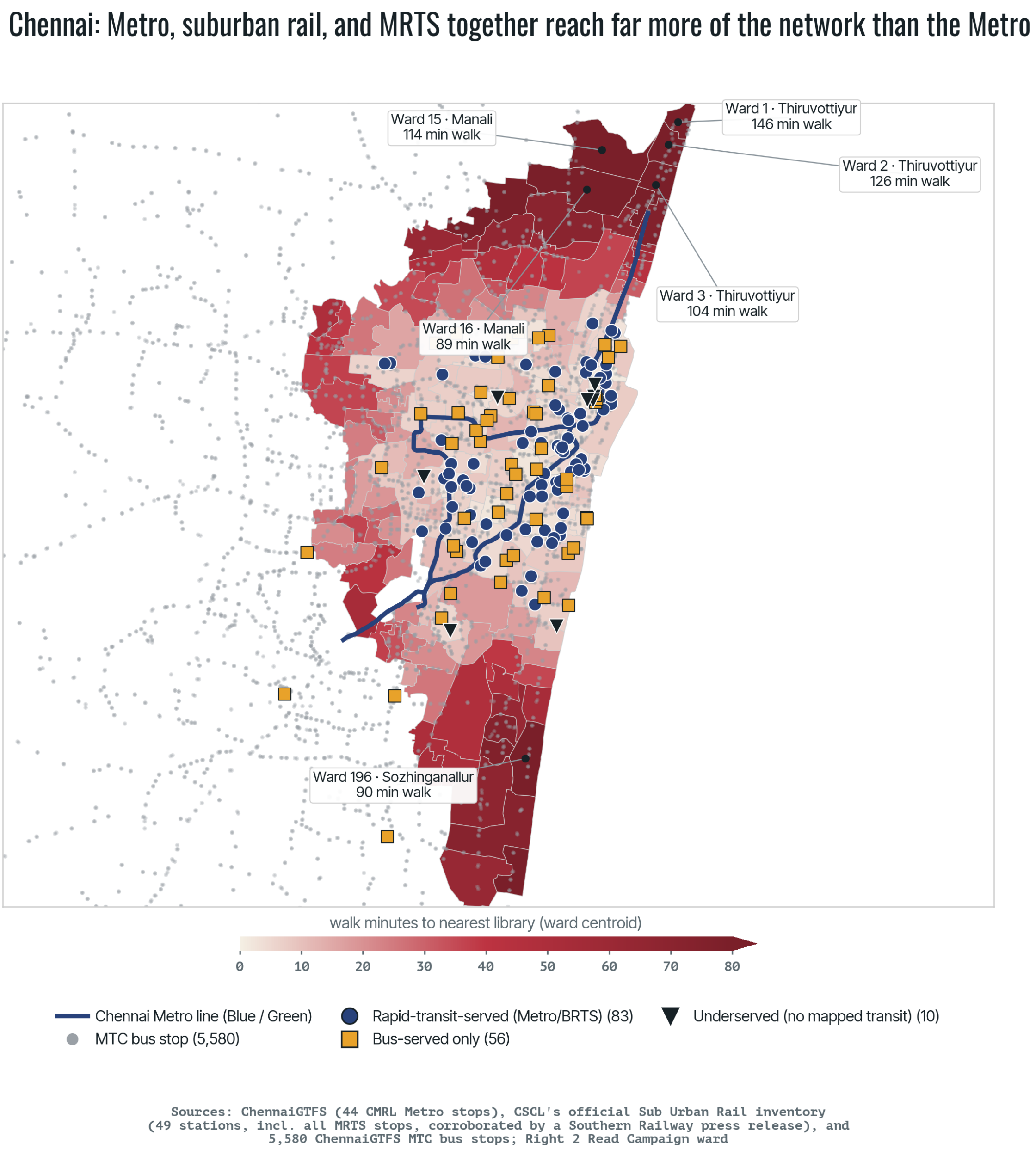


Figure 6: Chennai transit siting. The 149 register libraries (address-level geocoded) classified by transit access over the same walk-time surface: blue circles rapid-transit-served (within 800 m of a Chennai Metro or Southern Railway suburban-rail/MRTS station), gold squares bus-served only (within 400 m of an MTC stop), black triangles underserved. 83 are rapid-transit-served, 56 bus-served only, and 10 beyond 400 m of any mapped stop; the Metro traces the central and southern IT spine while the 2011-annexed industrial fringe rides the bus and the suburban line. Metro and bus from ChennaiGTFS; suburban rail (including MRTS) from Chennai Smart City Limited's official Sub Urban Rail inventory, corroborated by a Southern Railway press release — closing the earlier Metro-only undercount.

9 Kolkata: A Legislated Network, Disclosed and Defunded

Kolkata completes the three-way contrast, and it is the corrective case: the reading here is not a network made invisible but a network **disclosed and then defunded**. West Bengal legislated public reading through the **West Bengal Public Libraries Act, 1979**, a near-replica of the Madras Act, and — crucially — it publishes what that Act built. The state's Department of Mass Education Extension and Library Services discloses the network on its own portal: **2,480 libraries** — 13 government libraries, about 2,460 government-sponsored (19 district, 232 town and sub-divisional, some 2,209 rural and primary units), and 7 aided — with the **State Central Library** at Ultadanga at its apex and named Kolkata libraries listed with their addresses. The city also holds the disclosed landmarks of Indian public reading: the **National Library of India** at Alipore, the country's largest; the **Asiatic Society**; the **Kolkata Metropolitan Library**; and the headquarters, in Salt Lake, of the **Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation**, the Centre's own public-library funding body. This is not a network the state hides. An earlier version of this analysis, working only from OpenStreetMap's seven Kolkata library points, misread that OSM gap as the city's; the official record and even a routine geocoding pass say otherwise.

To hold Kolkata to the same spatial standard as the other cities, we assembled a geocoded surface from findable, official-adjacent sources rather than OSM: a Google Places search across the Kolkata Municipal Corporation area returned **249 library points** — 104 strictly public (public libraries, *pathagars*, *granthagars*, the State and municipal libraries), a further 113 community and named libraries, and a residue of university, institutional, and commercial self-study halls set aside — to which we added the six named official anchors above, each geocoded to its address. One honest limit bounds this: the authoritative per-library register with locations, wbpublibnet.gov.in, is geo-fenced to India and could not be reached from this vantage, so even 249 points is a **lower bound** on a network the state itself counts in the thousands.

On that surface the spatial finding inverts the earlier draft. Over the 141 KMC wards the open layer carries (three short of the statutory 144, the newest Joka additions absent), **130 fall within a 1.2 km walk** of a findable library and 109 within a walk of a strictly public one; the median ward-centroid walk is 7 to 9 minutes, and roughly 99 per cent of wards lie within a 30-minute walk. The library-poor tail is short and peripheral — the western Garden Reach and Metiaburuz riverfront wards and the eastern fringe around ward 108 sit half an hour to three-quarters of an hour out, the sharpest being a 44-minute walk, a world away from the two-hour peripheries of Ahmedabad or Chennai. Access, in other words, is not where Kolkata's public library fails. The network is dense, disclosed, and reachable.

The real finding is fiscal, and it is where Kolkata rejoins the paper's spine. The 1979 Act copied the Madras statute in almost every respect but **dropped the library cess**: West Bengal's public libraries are funded not by a ring-fenced surcharge on property tax but from the state's consolidated fund through discretionary grants. Where Tamil Nadu's cess pays for the Chennai network and Karnataka and Telangana levy a reading tax and then withhold it (Section 6, Section 7), West Bengal never ring-fenced one at all — and the consequence is a network kept dense and disclosed on paper while it is hollowed from within. Field research documents a de facto librarian recruitment freeze from roughly 2010 into the early 2020s, with more than four-fifths of the state's rural libraries reduced to a single staff member before recruitment was tentatively restarted in 2023–24 against a large accumulated backlog. The buildings are on the map and in the register; the staff, the hours, and the acquisitions behind them

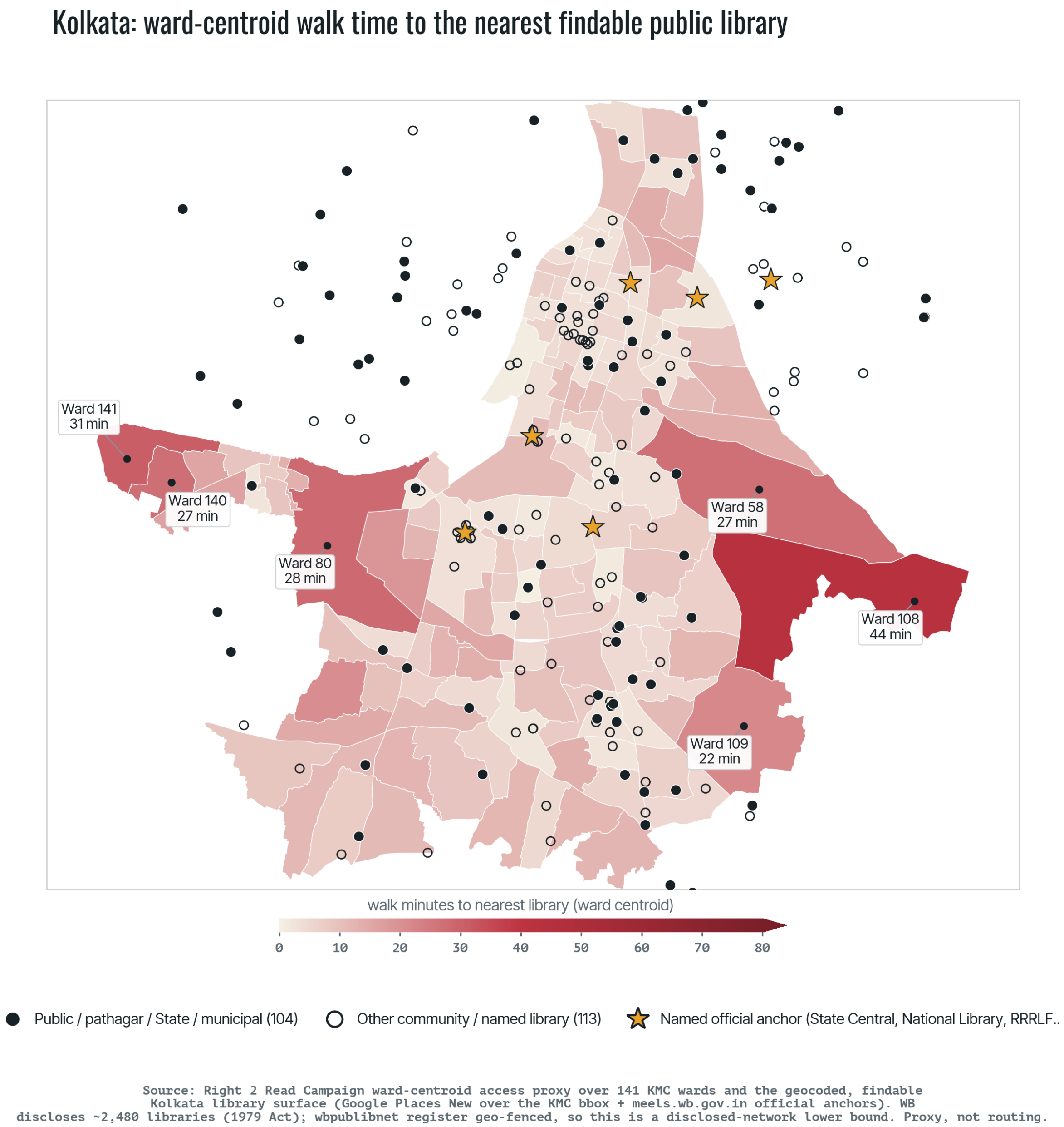


Figure 7: Kolkata access proxy. Straight-line distance from each of the 141 KMC ward centroids to the nearest of the geocoded, findable Kolkata library surface (Google Places across the KMC area + the named official anchors); filled dots are strictly public / pathagar / State / municipal libraries, hollow dots other community and named libraries, gold stars the named official anchors (State Central Library, National Library, RRRLF, Asiatic Society, Kolkata Metropolitan, Bangiya Sahitya Parishad). West Bengal discloses ~2,480 libraries; the authoritative wbpublibnet register is geo-fenced, so this findable surface is a disclosed-network lower bound.

are what a non-statutory, grant-dependent funding model has let lapse — a decay the location data alone cannot show, and which the service fields (circulation, membership, staffing, per-branch hours) would, if West Bengal disclosed them at the branch level as fully as it discloses its counts. That is the one genuine disclosure wrinkle here: the state publishes how *many* libraries it runs, and a searchable network portal, but the fullest per-library register with locations sits behind an India-only geo-fence, and the service performance behind the counts is not published at all.

Transit siting carried a heavier caveat in Kolkata than almost anywhere else in the set, because the mode that actually moves the metropolitan working class — the suburban railway — was mostly absent from the classification the 2026-07-03 draft could build. Kolkata's rapid-transit spine is the **suburban railway**, run by two Indian Railways zones, Eastern Railway (the Howrah and Sealdah divisions) and South Eastern Railway, the largest suburban network in the country, carrying several million riders a day, far more than the Metro. Even the Metro is an Indian Railways asset here: Metro Railway, Kolkata, has been the seventeenth zone of Indian Railways since 2010, the only metro in India run directly by the national railway. Below the rail, the everyday network is buses: the state undertaking (WBTC) alongside a large **private-bus** network that runs on route permits issued by the state transport authority and on fares fixed by state-government notification under the Motor Vehicles Act — a regulated, low-fare system (an ordinary-bus minimum of a few rupees), not a deregulated private market. sevent4 has since constructed public layers for all four of these modes (Eastern/South Eastern Railway suburban-rail stations, Metro stations, WBTC bus stops, and the route-permitted private-bus network), so this revision reclassifies the 217-point findable surface against the full set rather than Metro and bus alone: **112 points are rapid-transit-served, 39 are bus-served only, and 66 lie beyond 400 m of any mapped stop**. Rail, not the Metro, does almost all of that rapid-transit work — consistent with the suburban railway being the dominant mode this section opens with. The underserved share is real and higher than the earlier Metro-only reading implied transit alone could explain, which sharpens rather than softens the paper's fiscal argument: a library surface this well served by four separate public transit networks still has two-thirds of its points a walk away from any of them, so Kolkata's library problem, as the fiscal reading below argues, is money and staff, not the transit grid.

A caste reading of this surface remains a measured gap rather than a finding: neither the open ward layer nor any of the eleven Assembly Constituencies in frame carries a Scheduled-Caste reservation or an SC/ST share, so the ward-level cross that Ahmedabad allowed cannot be run for Kolkata without primary data. What Kolkata contributes to the argument is the third term of the typology the built-out cases now make legible. Chennai funds its network by statute and it works; Ahmedabad sustains its network on municipal legacy without a funding law, precariously; and Kolkata legislates and discloses a large network but, having dropped the cess, lets it decay for want of the money to staff and stock it. The withdrawal here is neither at the counter nor at the ledger. It is at the budget line: a network the state is content to count, and even to map, but not to fund.

10 Mumbai: The Bombay Model — a Fixed Floor, No Cess, and a Governance Capture

Mumbai is the second founding lineage, and the antithesis Chennai has to be read against. Where Tamil Nadu's 1948 Act funds reading with a buoyant cess, Maharashtra's **Maharashtra Public Libraries**

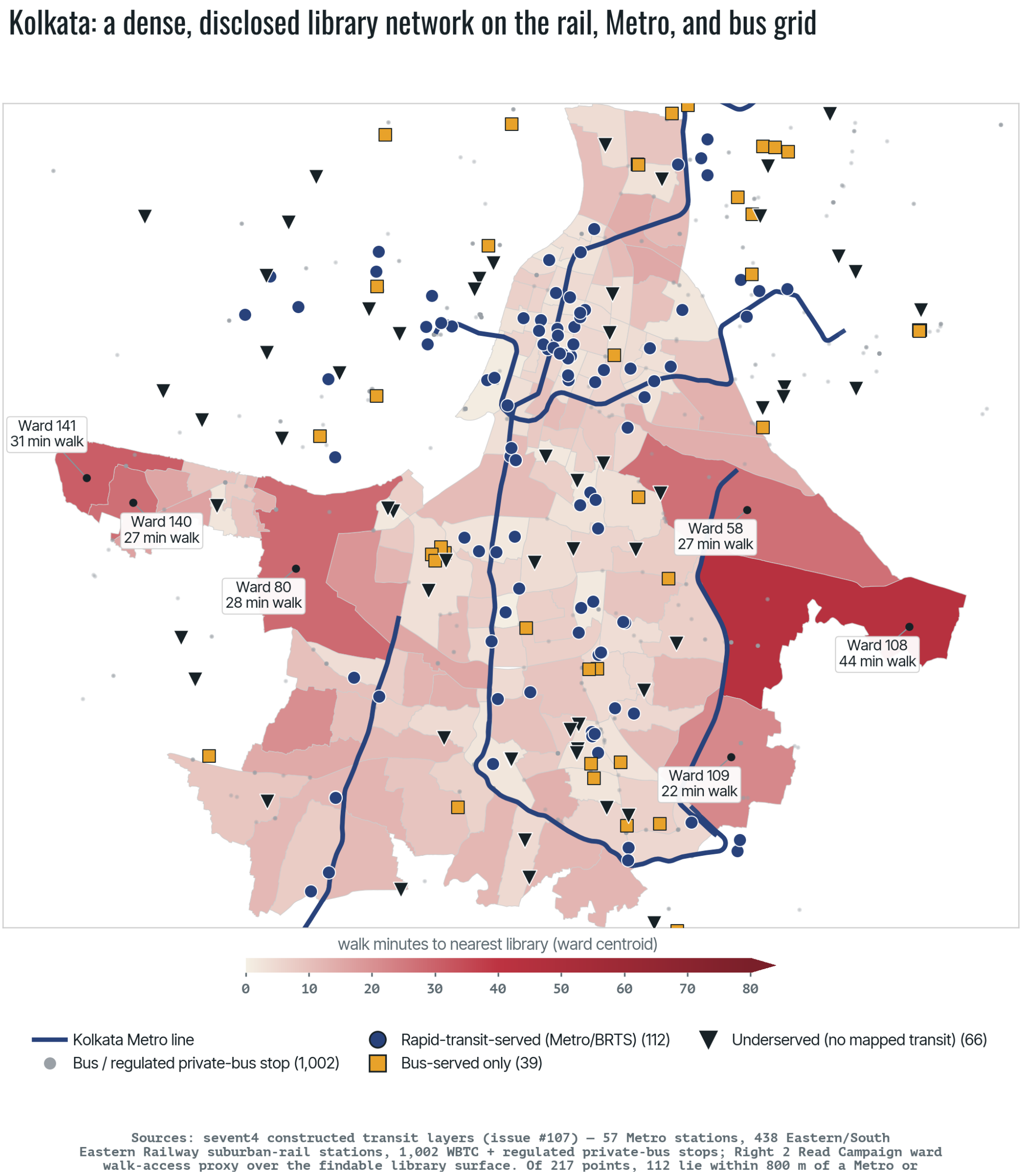


Figure 8: Kolkata transit siting. The 217-point findable library surface classified by transit access over the same walk-time surface: blue circles rapid-transit-served (within 800 m of a Kolkata Metro or Eastern/South Eastern Railway suburban-rail station), gold squares bus-served only (within 400 m of a WBTC or regulated private-bus stop), black triangles underserved. 112 are rapid-transit-served, 39 bus-served only, and 66 beyond 400 m of any mapped stop. Constructed from sevent4's suburban-rail, Metro, and combined bus layers (issue #107), closing the earlier Metro-and-bus-only undercount.

Act, 1967, built the same institutional scaffolding — a State Library Council, a Directorate, a network of divisional and district libraries — and then declined the one instrument that would have paid for it. The Act levies **no library cess**. Its statutory guarantee is instead a floor: the State Government "shall … contribute to the Library Fund every year, a sum not less than twenty-five lakhs of rupees," with everything above that figure discretionary. That ₹25-lakh floor was set in 1967 and never indexed; six decades of inflation have reduced it to a token, so that the only sum the law actually promises the reading commons is now trivially small, and the rest depends on the annual goodwill of the budget. This is the Bombay model in a sentence: not a reading tax that grows with the city's property base, but a decaying grant fixed in the currency of 1967. The unit here is the Greater Mumbai public-library system read across the 227 electoral wards (*prabhags*) of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation.

Faced with the chance to correct toward the Madras model, Maharashtra has recently done the opposite. The **Maharashtra Public Libraries (Amendment) Act, 2024** (Mah. Act No. XIII of 2025), in force from 15 October 2024, modernises the statute — it adds e-resources to the definition of library material and, for the first time, makes a District Library mandatory in every district — but on funding and control it doubles down.[10] It adds **no cess.** It rewrites the State Library Council so that its members, formerly **elected**, are now **nominated by the State Government** — the word "elected" is struck and "nominated" put in its place — and a new section provides that a nominated member "shall hold office *during the pleasure of the Government* and shall be removed at any time by the Government, if it deems fit." A body that once carried an elected element is thus converted into one that sits entirely at the executive's pleasure: a governance capture written into the statute. And in place of a public revenue stream, the amendment opens the Library Fund to a new source — "any contribution or donations made by public trust, private trust, co-operative society, local authority, **company and industrial enterprises** for public libraries." The reading commons is to be financed, that is, not by a tax the city owes itself but by the corporate-social-responsibility budgets of whichever companies choose to give. Governance capture and private-money substitution arrive together, in the same Act, in the one metropolis whose founding law already refused the cess.

The spatial record has to be reconstructed the same way as Kolkata's, and for the same reason: the open geospatial layer is an OpenStreetMap artefact, not the network. For all of Greater Mumbai, OSM's `amenity=library` returns only 47 points. Against that, a Google Places search across the BMC area returned **214 library points** — 44 strictly public (public libraries, *vachanalayas*, *granthalayas*, the State and municipal libraries), a further 133 community and named libraries, and a residue of institutional and commercial self-study halls set aside — to which we added six named official anchors, each geocoded to its address: the Asiatic Society of Mumbai in the Town Hall, the David Sassoon Library, the People's Free Reading Room, the J.N. Petit Institute, the Mumbai Marathi Grantha Sangrahalaya, and the State Central Library, one of the four National Depository Libraries under the Delivery of Books Act, 1954. The **findable surface** is 177 points (public plus community); the **strictly-public subset** is 44. As everywhere else in this paper, the register discloses *locations*; the service fields the IFLA frame expects — per-branch hours, seating, collection, staff, circulation, membership — are absent, and remain an RTI gap.

On the findable surface, and for once with a genuine population weighting rather than a ward count,

[10] Maharashtra Public Libraries (Amendment) Act, 2024 (Mah. Act No. XIII of 2025), first published after the Governor's assent on 1 January 2025, deemed in force from 15 October 2024; amending the Maharashtra Public Libraries Act, 1967 (Mah. XXXIV of 1967). Provisions cited from the Gazette translation: §3(3) and the substituted clause (xiv); new §6A(3); and §18(2), clause (e).

Mumbai looks well served: **162 of the 227 prabhags fall within a 1.2 km walk** of a findable library, the population-weighted median walk is about 11 minutes, and roughly **71 per cent of residents are within a 15-minute walk, 94 per cent within 30 minutes**. Access, as in Kolkata, is not where the Bombay model plainly fails; a dense city has a dense scatter of reading rooms. But restrict the surface to the 44 **strictly public** libraries and the picture thins sharply: only 72 prabhags lie within a 1.2 km walk, barely **32 per cent of residents are within a 15-minute walk of an actual public library**, and the ninetieth-percentile walk runs to three-quarters of an hour. The worst-served wards are not random. They are **M-East ward — Govandi, Mankhurd, Deonar** — where prabhags sit **an hour and a half to more than an hour and a half from the nearest public library** (Prabhag 145 at roughly 93 minutes, 146 at 79, several others at 65–66), with Bhandup in the north-east close behind. M-East is Mumbai's poorest and most segregated ward, abutting the Deonar dumping ground — the city's clearest instance of what Banerjee and Mehta call the "post-liberalisation Dalit ghetto" (Banerjee and Mehta 2017), and the direct heir of the Bombay in which, as Juned Shaikh shows, industrial capitalism and caste operated in "symbiosis," Dalit neighbourhoods were marked as slums, and "language and literature" were themselves a site of Dalit struggle (Shaikh 2021). The public reading room reaches this ward last.

Siting against the rapid network repeats the pattern the other cities set, with a Mumbai particularity: the metropolis has no metro layer in the open data at all, because its rapid-transit spine has never been the Metro. It is the **suburban railway** — the Western, Central, and Harbour lines, run by the Western and Central Railway zones of Indian Railways, that carry the working city — supplemented since 2014 by a still-expanding Metro. This paper's own dedicated harvest gives 148 rapid stations (73 Metro, 75 suburban rail) — tested against sevent4's newer constructed Metro and suburban-rail layers (issue #107, 177 stations combined) and kept in preference to them, since the larger raw count covers the libraries' actual locations less completely, not more. Bus siting does use sevent4's newly official BEST/KDMT layer (7,195 stops, up from a 2,631-point OSM extract). Of the 177 findable libraries, **128 lie within 800 m of a rapid station, 47 are bus-served only, and 2 are beyond any mapped stop**. The suburban rail, unlike the Metro elsewhere, does reach the libraries, because it reaches almost everything; but the strictly-public network that thins at M-East thins precisely where the rail's eastern harbour arm runs past without a reading room to serve.

Mumbai is also where the caste question, a measured gap in every other city here, can at last be measured. Alone among the seven, the BMC prabhag layer carries Census-derived Scheduled-Caste and Scheduled-Tribe counts per ward, so the exclusion cross Ahmedabad could run only on slum-census proxies can here be run on real per-ward caste shares. The result is a real, if moderate, gradient — and it runs the way the argument predicts. City-wide the Scheduled-Caste and Scheduled-Tribe share is 7.5 per cent. Crossing each prabhag's SC/ST share against its distance to the nearest **public** library and splitting the city at the two population-weighted medians, **64 of the 227 prabhags fall in the double-locked quadrant** — above the median on both axes, both more caste-marked and farther from a public library — and those 64 hold **3.52 million residents, 28 per cent of the city**. The far wards average an 8.9 per cent SC/ST share against 6.1 per cent in the near wards; and the 17 prabhags reserved for Scheduled-Caste or Scheduled-Tribe candidates average a **31.5-minute walk to a public library against 24.6 minutes for the rest**. The gap is not enormous — Mumbai is not Ahmedabad's double-locked quadrant — but it is real, and unlike every other city here it is measured on actual per-ward caste counts rather than inferred from a proxy, which is why it can be stated with

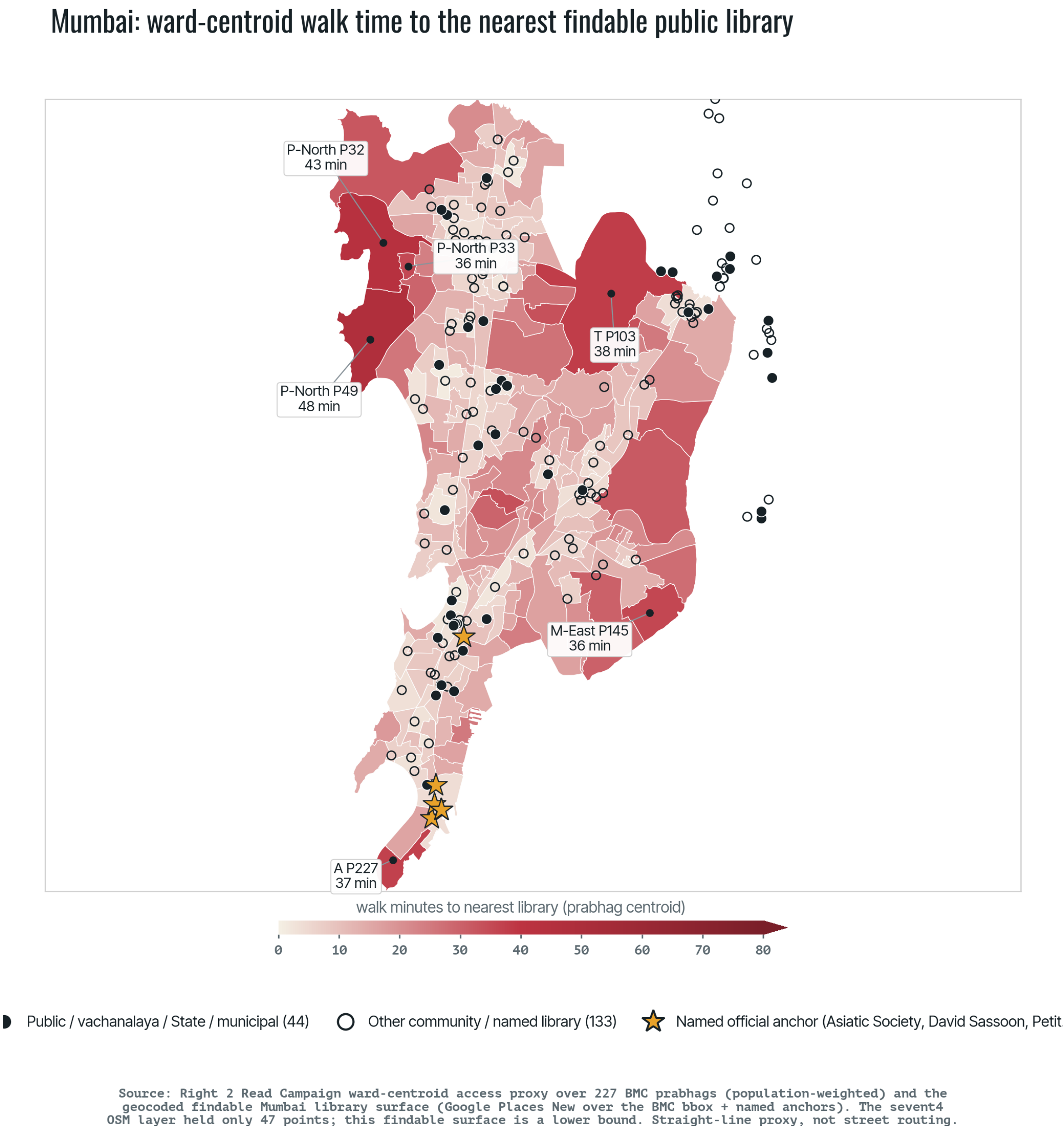


Figure 9: Mumbai access proxy. Population-weighted straight-line distance from each of the 227 BMC prabhag centroids to the nearest of the 177 findable library points (Google Places across the BMC area + named anchors); filled dots are the 44 strictly public / *vachanalaya* / State / municipal libraries, hollow dots other community and named libraries, gold stars the named official anchors. The sevent4 OpenStreetMap layer held only 47 points, so this findable surface is a lower bound. A straight-line proxy, not a street-network travel-time model.

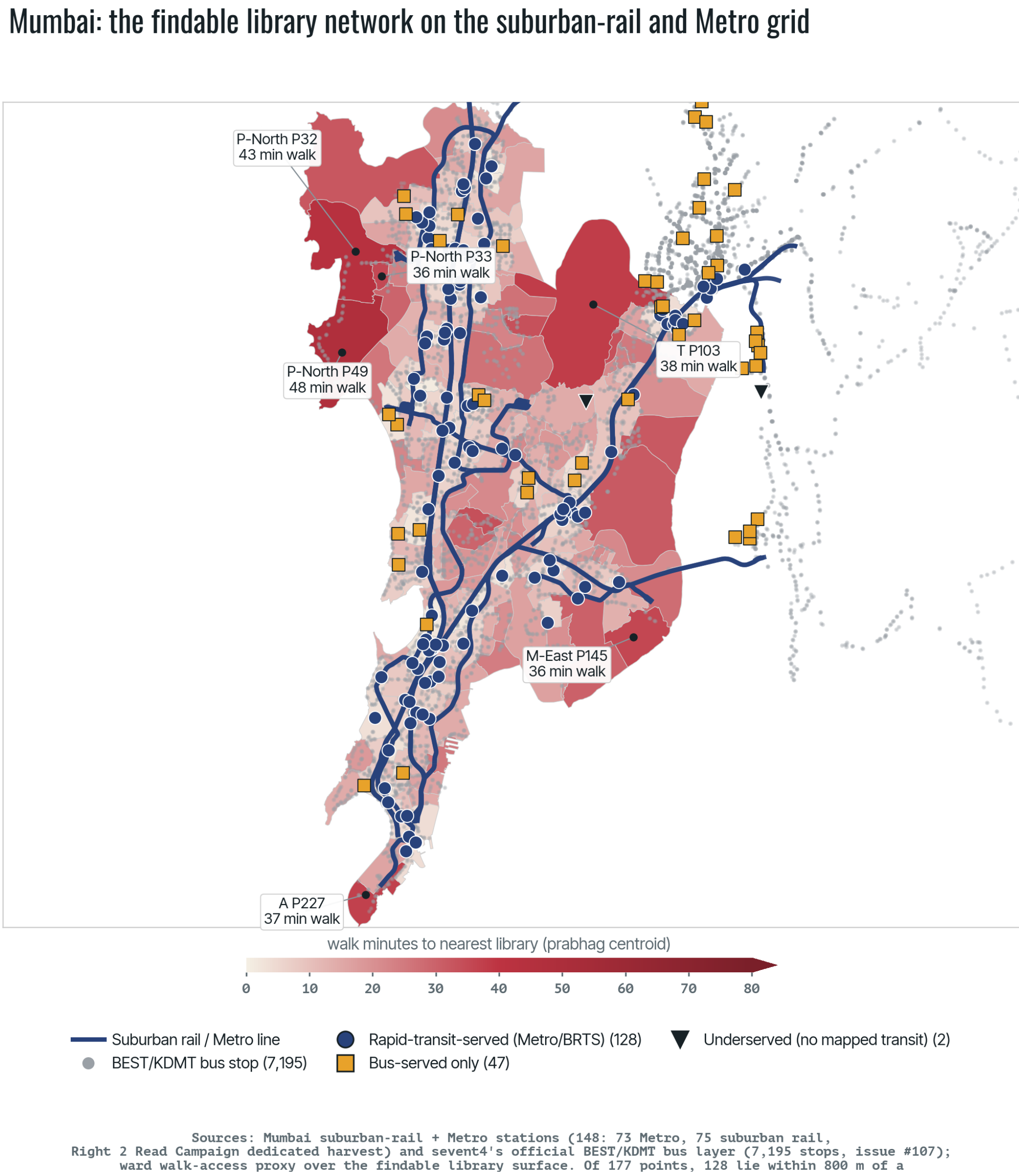


Figure 10: Mumbai transit siting. The findable library surface classified by transit access over the same walk-time surface: blue circles rapid-transit-served (within 800 m of a suburban-rail or Metro station), gold squares bus-served only, black triangles underserved. Mumbai's rapid-transit spine is the suburban railway (Western/Central/Harbour), not the Metro; rapid stations are this paper's own dedicated harvest, bus stops are sevent4's official BEST/KDMT layer (issue #107).

more confidence than the findable-surface access figures around it. Measured on the strictly-public points, the pattern points one way: the wards with the most Dalit and Adivasi residents are, on average, the wards a public library reaches last. That is a measured regularity, not a demonstrated mechanism — it invites the question of why the public tier thins where it does, rather than closing it — but it is the firmest caste signal the seven cities yield.

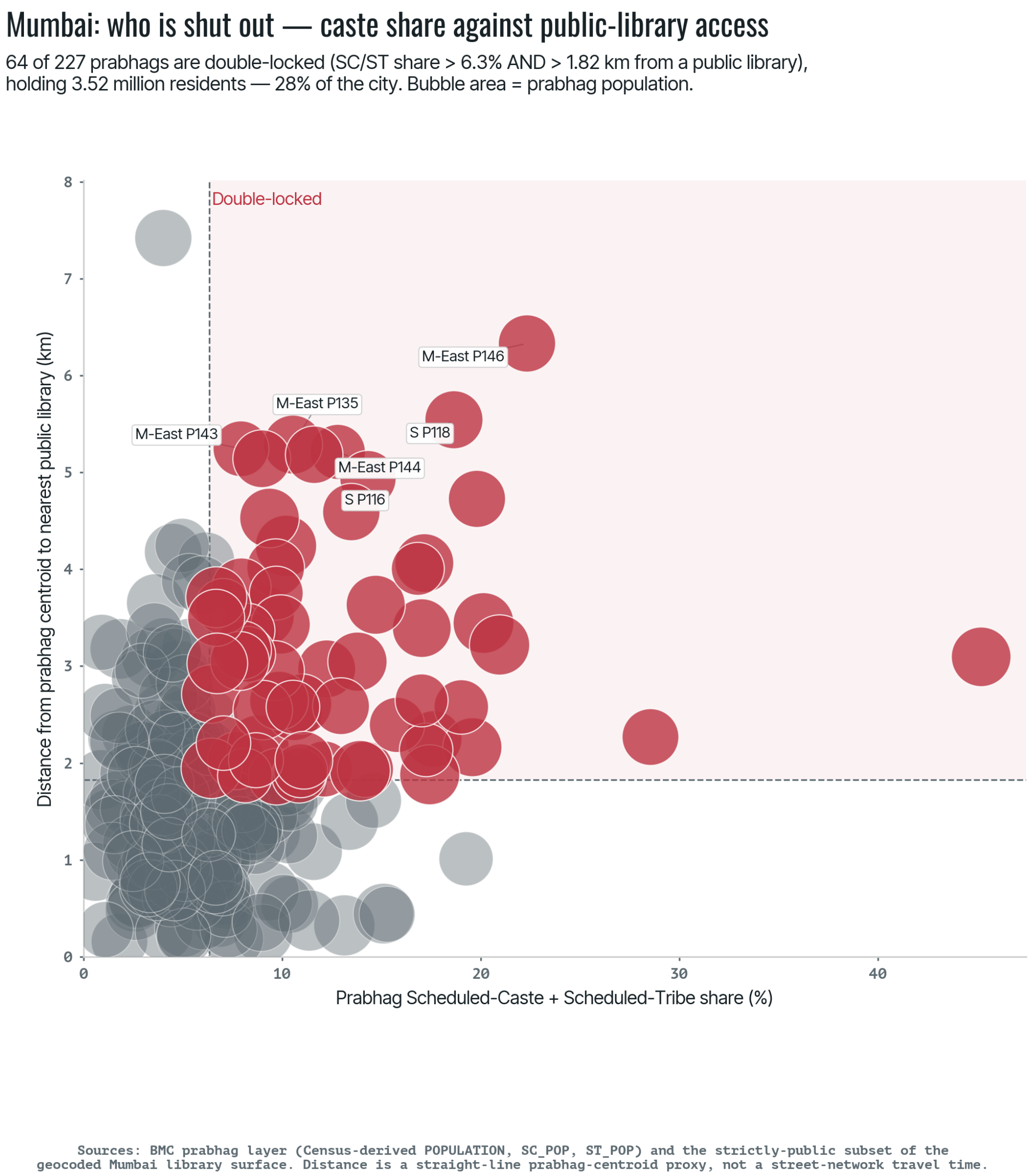


Figure 11: Mumbai caste exclusion cross. Each prabhag's Scheduled-Caste-plus-Scheduled-Tribe share (horizontal) against the distance from its centroid to the nearest strictly-public library (vertical), with bubble area proportional to prabhag population. The shaded top-right quadrant is double-locked: above the population-weighted median on both axes. Sixty-four prabhags holding 3.52 million residents fall inside it; the M-East (Govandi/Mankhurd/Deonar) and Bhandup prabhags are the extremes.

Mumbai completes the two-lineage typology the paper is built around. Chennai is the Madras model working: a statutory authority, a buoyant cess, a network dense and disclosed because the law pays for it. Mumbai is the Bombay model as it has aged: the same authority, but funded from the start by a fixed grant rather than a cess, its statutory floor decayed to a token, and now — in the 2024 amendment

— its council captured by nomination and its fund opened to corporate charity in the cess's place. And the two intermediate lineages fill the space between: Bengaluru and Hyderabad, which took the Madras cess and let the corporation withhold it; Kolkata, which copied the Madras Act and dropped the cess; Ahmedabad, which legislated no funding instrument at all. Read across the seven, the fiscal design is not incidental to whether the reading commons survives. It is the whole of it. Where a city funds reading out of a dedicated, growing public revenue, the library is dense, disclosed, and — its periphery aside — reachable. Everywhere the cess is refused, withheld, dropped, or never levied, the library persists as an address and recedes as a service, and it recedes first from the wards where the country's most excluded readers live.

11 The Seven Cities and the Two Lineages

The seven cities do not fail in the same way, and the difference tracks the funding instrument each inherited. Placed against the two founding lineages, they form a range from the reading commons paid for out of dedicated public revenue to the reading commons left to a decaying grant and private money:

City	Lineage	Statute & funding instrument	Fiscal reality	Where the library fails
Chennai	Madras	TN (Madras) Public Libraries Act, 1948 — statutory authority + **buoyant library cess**.	Cess levied and paid to the authority.	Least: dense, disclosed; thins only at the 2011-annexed edge. Service fields unreported.
Bengaluru	Madras (copied)	Karnataka Public Libraries Act, 1965 — **6% library cess**.	Cess collected by BBMP and **withheld** (~₹700 cr in arrears).	Funded on paper, starved at source; network poorly disclosed.
Hyderabad	Madras (copied)	Telangana Public Libraries Act, 1960 — **library cess** (up to 8 paise/rupee).	Cess collected by GHMC and **withheld** (~₹175 cr over ~15 yrs).	Same withholding; open data captures under a tenth of the network.
Kolkata	Madras replica, cess **dropped**	WB Public Libraries Act, 1979 — authority but **no cess**; consolidated-fund grants.	Grant-dependent; recruitment frozen c. 2010–2022.	Dense and disclosed, defunded from within; service decays.

City	Lineage	Statute & funding instrument	Fiscal reality	Where the library fails
Ahmedabad	No funding law	Gujarat Public Libraries Act, 2001 (No. 25 of 2001) — **no cess, no cess-substitute**.	Municipal budget lines; low single-digit ₹/resident.	Municipal legacy without statutory scaffolding; precarious.
Mumbai	Bombay	Maharashtra Public Libraries Act, 1967 — **no cess**; fixed ≥₹25-lakh grant floor. 2024 amendment: council nominated, fund opened to CSR.	Un-indexed floor decayed to a token; governance captured.	Public network thin at the caste-marked periphery (M-East).
Delhi	Union-run	Delhi Library Board / Ministry of Culture (Union-funded).	Central budget; circulation collapsed, ~half of posts vacant.	Federal deflection; thin fixed estate, staffing crisis.

Set side by side, the two disclosure-and-service cases the paper opened on remain the sharpest illustration of the shared symptom. Ahmedabad shows a denser municipal footprint — 83 locations, 26,834 registered users and 96,491 loans in 2025–26 against an 811,093-item collection — but discloses seating, hours, branch collection, and collection type for none of them. Delhi shows more registered users (110,534 in 2023–24) and a larger collection (1,527,531) across a 111-row hierarchy, but that hierarchy mixes fixed libraries, mobile stops, reading centres, and buses, and sits on a staffing crisis that has driven circulation from over a million issues a year to 274,751 and vacancies toward half. One system is denser and blanker; the other is better-documented at the system level and hollow at the branch. Neither lets a citizen see the service.

The shared finding, across all seven, is the same: public-library evidence in Indian cities is still too often institutional evidence rather than service evidence. We can see boards, buildings, collections, grants, and — in Chennai, Kolkata, and Mumbai — even the map of locations. We cannot yet see enough about hours, seats, staff, use, digital access, and branch-level performance. And beneath the disclosure gap runs the fiscal one: the cities that fund reading out of a dedicated, growing public revenue keep the commons alive, and the cities that refuse, withhold, drop, or never levy that revenue let it recede — first, and farthest, from the wards where the most excluded readers live. The rest of the paper takes that failure apart along the five conditions of public-ness.

12 Disclosure: Can the Service Be Seen?

The first condition is that the service can be seen well enough to be judged. Here the Indian cases fail before any question of quality arises. As Section 4 and Section 5 showed, Ahmedabad discloses seating, branch collection size, and collection type for none of its 83 locations, and weekly hours for none; Delhi publishes system-level annual-report aggregates but almost nothing at the branch level. Infrastructure is characteristically invisible until it breaks — and here the invisibility is itself the failure, because a service that is never disclosed cannot be audited, and a withdrawal that cannot be audited proceeds unchallenged.

Toronto is the lens that shows what disclosure makes possible. Toronto Public Library reports at both branch and system level:

Field	Toronto value
Branches / service points	102
Material borrowings	28,000,000
Branch visits	13,400,000
Collection items	10,500,000
New card registrations	235,270

No per-resident league table is drawn from these figures, and deliberately so: ranking a three-million-person North American city against a twenty-million-person subcontinental capital by borrowings-per-head would flatten exactly the differences this paper is trying to see, and would concede that the Indian city is a deficient copy of a Western one. What Toronto shows is narrower and portable — that a public-library system *can* report itself at branch and system level, in a form that makes citizen audit routine. That form of disclosure is a choice, and nothing about a city's size, wealth, or history makes it unavailable. It is the choice the Indian systems here have not made; the argument against them stands on their own records, not on a comparison with the West.

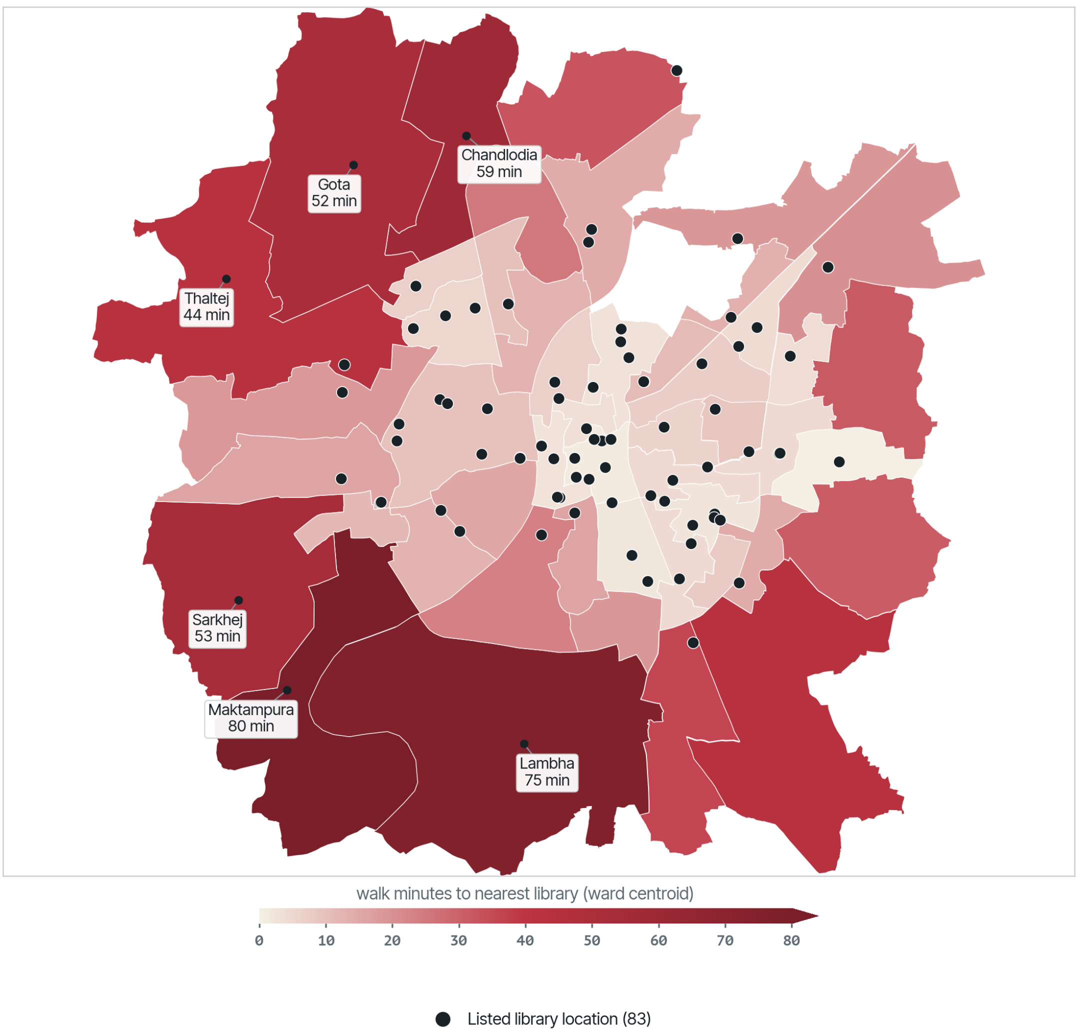
13 Reach: Can People Get to the Library?

A library that can be seen must still be reachable. Counting buildings is not enough; the test is whether libraries sit near population, schools, transit, and everyday pedestrian routes, and whether a listed point is a full branch, a sub-branch, a reading room, or a scheduled mobile stop. This is the axis on which the international comparators are least informative and the Indian ward data most direct, so it is argued from that data.

For Ahmedabad, the location inventory is complete enough for a first-pass access diagnostic: all 83 listed library locations have coordinates. The first map below is a straight-line access proxy, not a street-network travel-time model. On current ward geometry, 28 of 48 ward centroids fall within 1.2 km of a listed library location, the median ward-centroid distance is 1.03 km, and about 31 percent of mapped ward area falls inside a 1.2 km straight-line buffer. That is useful for triage, but it is not a population-weighted access audit.

The second Ahmedabad map tests siting against everyday anchors rather than treating the library list as self-explanatory. In the current mapped layers, 77 of 83 listed libraries are within 400 m of a mapped bus

Ahmedabad: ward-centroid walk time to the nearest listed library



Source: Right 2 Read Campaign ward-centroid access proxy over 48 AMC wards and 83 listed library locations (normalized inventory). 28 of 48 ward centroids fall within 1.2 km (~15-min walk); median ward-centroid distance 1.03 km. Straight-line proxy, not street-network routing.

Figure 12: Ahmedabad's 83 listed library locations against ward boundaries. The shaded surface is the distance from each ward centroid to the nearest listed library, with a 1.2 km straight-line buffer around library points. Lambha, Ramol Hathijan, and Vastral are outlined as priority wards for further testing, not as final catchment findings.

stop, 30 are within 800 m of a Metro station, and 32 are within 400 m of a BRTS corridor. This is still a context map. The capacity-aware model will need ward population, AMTS/BRTS/Metro frequency, schools and colleges, ward deprivation, and public-space deficits. Lambha, Ramol Hathijan, and Vastral were earlier flagged as priority wards because they combine high population with service-gap signals; the next paragraph runs the spatial join those flags were waiting on.

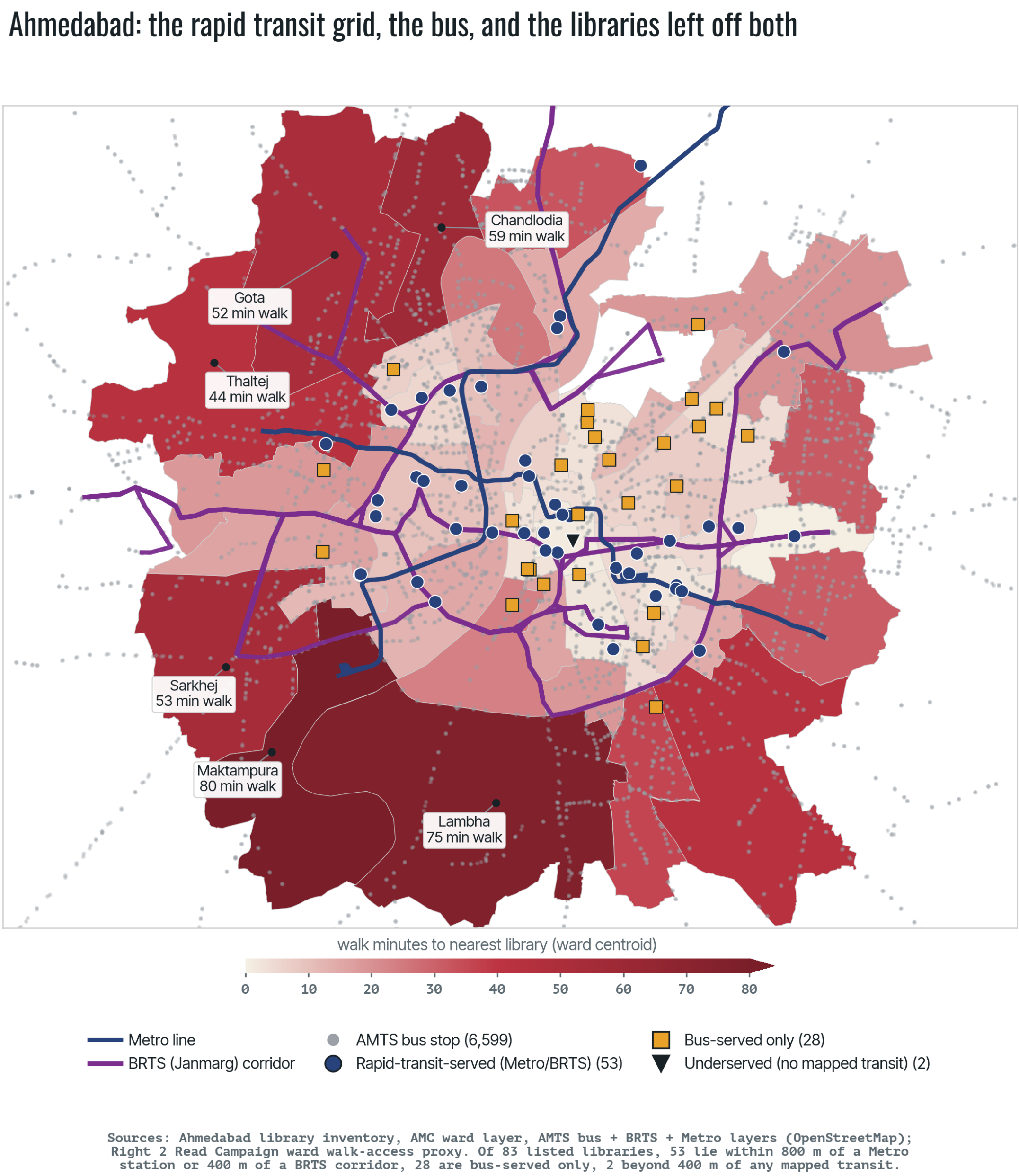


Figure 13: Ahmedabad's 83 listed libraries classified by transit access over the ward walk-time surface (the same rtr_heat scale as the other city maps). Blue circles are rapid-transit-served (within 800 m of a Metro station or 400 m of a BRTS corridor), gold squares bus-served only (within 400 m of one of 6,599 AMTS stops), black triangles underserved. 53 are rapid-transit-served, 28 bus-served only, and 2 beyond 400 m of any mapped stop; the rapid grid and the libraries both cluster in the already-served core.

Crossing access against deprivation turns those leads into a measured pattern. For each ward we take the straight-line distance from its centroid to the nearest of the 83 listed libraries and place it against the ward deprivation index, then split the city at the two medians: deprivation 0.82 and distance 1.03

km. Fifteen of the 48 wards fall in the double-locked quadrant — above the median on both axes, so both materially deprived and far from a library. Those 15 wards hold 2.82 million residents, 40 percent of the mapped ward population. The three earlier leads are all confirmed double-locked: Lambha (deprivation 0.97, 6.0 km to the nearest library), Ramol Hathijan (0.97, 3.5 km), and Vastral (0.85, 2.5 km). They are not even the sharpest case. Maktampura is — deprivation 0.999, 6.4 km — followed by Lambha and then Sarkhej (0.97, 4.3 km). The ward layer's own precomputed library-desert flag is no help here, because it reads true for all 48 wards; access has to be measured directly, which is what this cross does. The deprivation axis is not caste-neutral either: Scheduled-Caste residents are 18.8 percent of the city's recorded slum population and Scheduled-Tribe residents a further 2.3 percent (ORGI Census 2011, town level), so the material deprivation mapped here sits inside a caste geography even where ward-level caste counts are not published. This is the spatial face of the same exclusion the membership gates impose administratively: the wards furthest from a library are also the wards whose residents are least able to satisfy an Aadhaar-plus-guarantor membership test, so distance and paperwork compound rather than substitute.

Delhi is further along spatially. For fixed DPL physical locations, the question is not whether DPL has 111 listed rows; 76 of those rows are mobile service points. The harder test is whether the 35 fixed physical locations are walkable and transit-linked. On the current ward geometry, only 57 of 290 wards, about 20 percent, fall within a 1.2 km walk of a fixed DPL location. The median ward sits 2.53 km from its nearest fixed DPL location, and only about 9 percent of the city's land area lies within the 1.2 km walk band. The pattern is concentrated in the older core while outer districts remain thinly served.

Transit only partly repairs the gap, and less than an earlier, coarser Metro layer suggested. Against DMRC's own official static GTFS (262 named stations, acquired by sevent4 from Open Transit Data Delhi, replacing an OpenStreetMap extract this map used before), only 6 of the 35 fixed DPL physical locations sit within 500 m of a Metro station, and 5 sit within 400 m — fewer than the earlier layer's coarser station positions implied. The bus network does better: 27 of the 35 fixed locations are within 400 m of a bus stop. Classified on the shared 800 m/400 m rapid/bus rule, 15 branches are rapid-transit-served, 16 are bus-served only, and 4 are beyond 400 m of any mapped stop. That means most branches are bus-reachable but not rapid-transit-reachable. The faster citywide network that could enlarge library catchments misses more than half the fixed DPL estate once Metro station positions are taken from DMRC's own feed rather than approximated.

The 1.2 km walking threshold is a deliberately strict floor. It excludes auto-rickshaw, two-wheeler, bicycle, app-cab, cycle-rickshaw, bus, and Metro trips. The walk standard is still necessary because children, students, older people, and carless residents are precisely the readers for whom a short, free trip matters most.

14 Entry: Can People Get In?

Reaching the building is not the same as being let in. Both Indian systems convert a public-service relationship into a test of documents, money, or social standing — and, as Section 4 and Section 5 set out, they do so hardest against the residents who most need a free reading space. Ahmedabad's rules are inconsistent and Aadhaar-forward, with a guarantor and a mobile OTP at the centre; Delhi gates adult membership through attestation by a gazetted officer or professional, or else a refundable INR

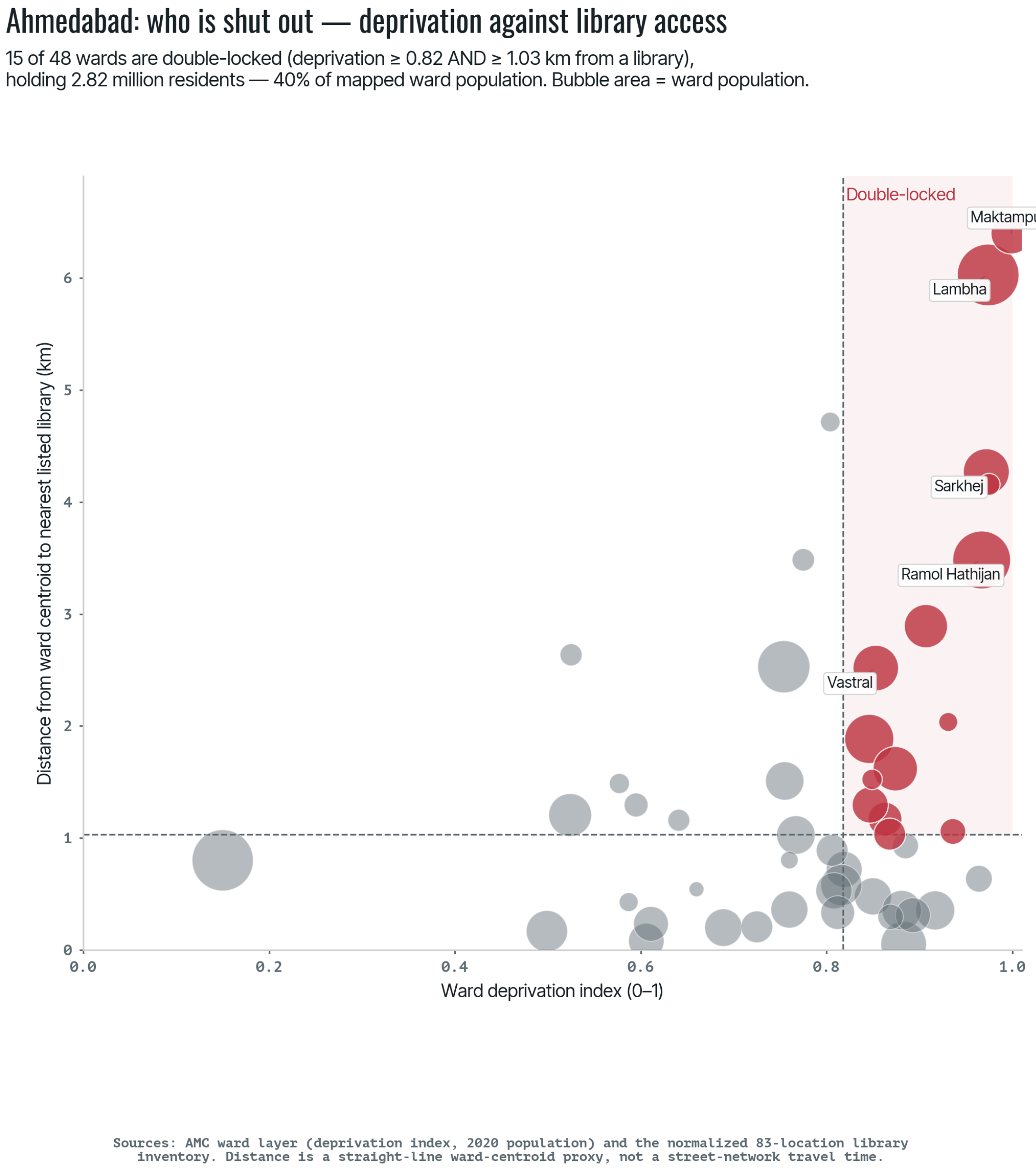


Figure 14: Ahmedabad wards crossed on deprivation (horizontal) and distance from the ward centroid to the nearest listed library (vertical), with bubble area proportional to ward population. The shaded top-right quadrant is double-locked: above the city median on both axes. Fifteen wards holding 2.82 million residents fall inside it; Lambha, Ramol Hathijan, and Vastral are confirmed, and Maktampura is the most extreme.

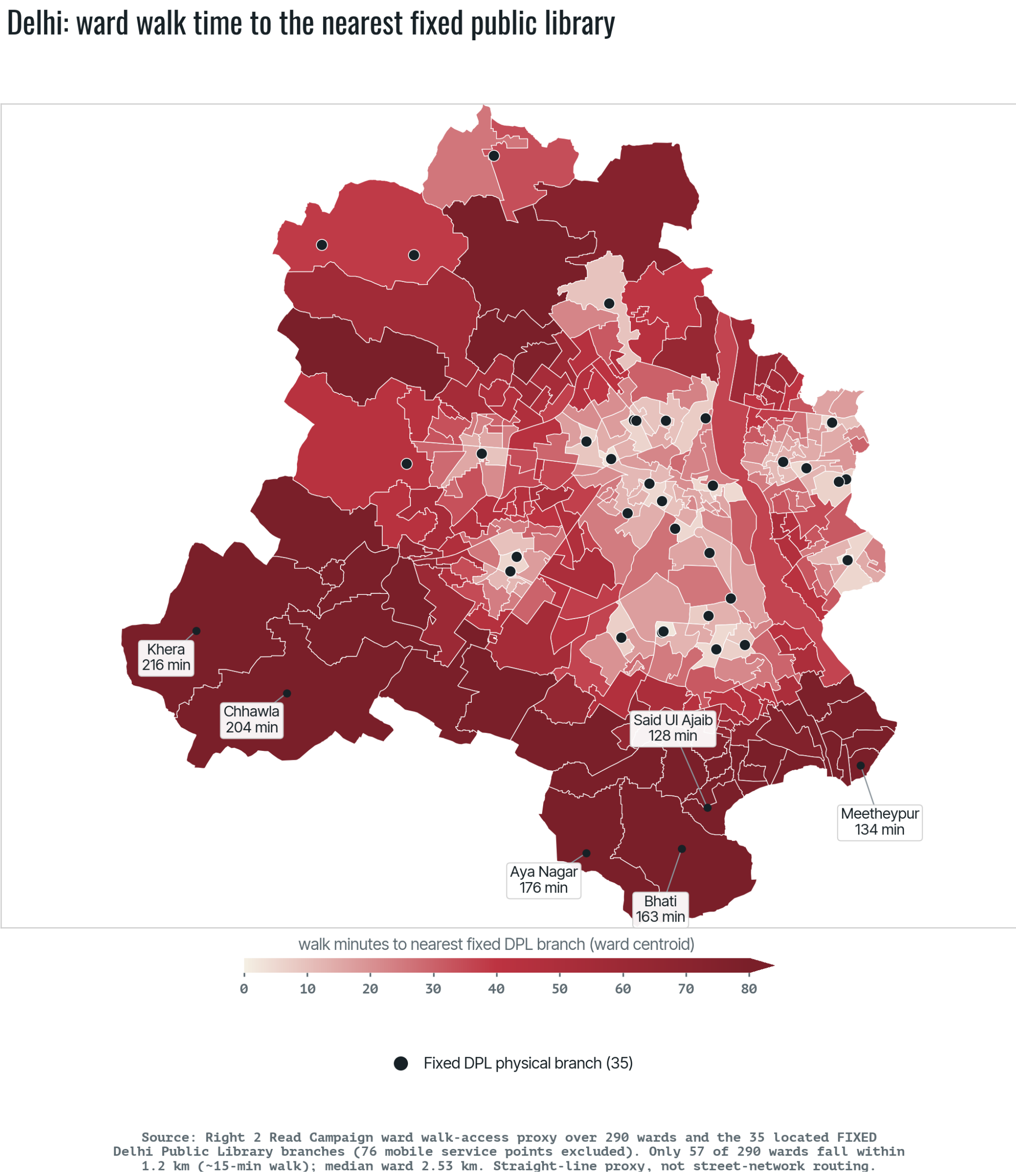


Figure 15: Distance from each Delhi ward to its nearest fixed DPL physical location. Only about 20 percent of wards lie within a 1.2 km walk, and barely 9 percent of the city's land area falls inside that walk band. Mobile service points are excluded from this fixed-location test.

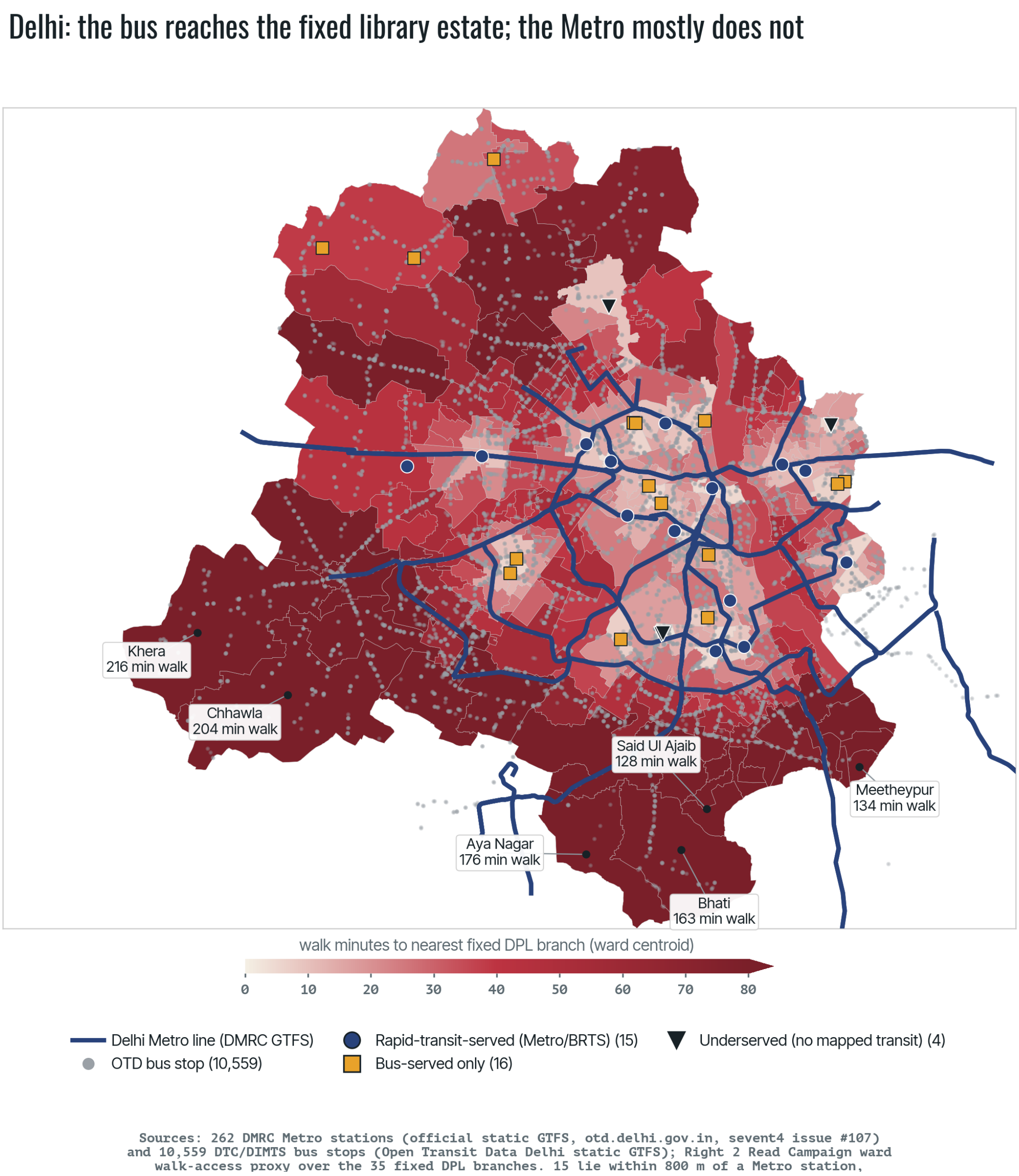


Figure 16: Delhi's 35 fixed DPL branches classified by transit access over the ward walk-time surface. Blue circles are within 800 m of a Metro station; gold squares are bus-served only (within 400 m of one of 10,559 Open Transit Data bus stops); black triangles are beyond 400 m of any mapped stop. 15 branches are rapid-transit-served, 16 bus-served only, and 4 underserved: the bus reaches the estate, the Metro mostly does not. Metro stations are DMRC's own official static GTFS (sevent4 issue #107), not an OpenStreetMap extract.

3,000 deposit. The ward residents who are farthest from a branch (Section 13) are also the least able to produce a guarantor or to lock up a fortnight's wages, so distance and paperwork compound rather than substitute.

Set against international practice, the two Indian systems are the outliers:

Library System	Residency Proof / Address Verification	ID Requirements	Guarantor Required for Adults?	Digital vs. Physical Access	Inclusion / Flexibility Features
Ahmedabad (M.J. Library)	**Inconsistent**: one rules block allows ration card, licence, passport, voter card, or Aadhaar; another membership blurb foregrounds Aadhaar; the online KYC dropdown narrows choices to Aadhaar, driving licence, or voter ID.	Photograph plus KYC document; online workflow also collects gender, education, date of birth, guarantor details, and mobile OTP.	**Yes** (Requires guarantor name/signature in the membership rules; online workflow asks guarantor name and mobile).	**Dual-track**: digital registration depends on valid mobile/OTP; physical M.J. membership requires KYC and librarian approval.	Low. Stated resident eligibility is broader than the actual proof and platform burden.
Delhi (DPL)	**Flexible**: Aadhaar, Voter ID, electricity bill, MTNL bill, bank passbook.	Valid photo ID.	**No** (But requires **attestation by a Gazetted Officer/professional** or a **refundable INR 3,000 security deposit**).	Standard in-person registration; outstation students get temporary 6-month cards.	Low-Medium. Attestation or deposit gates create heavy class/caste-based exclusion.

Library System	Residency Proof / Address Verification	ID Requirements	Guarantor Required for Adults?	Digital vs. Physical Access	Inclusion / Flexibility Features
New York Public Library (NYPL)	**Highly Flexible**: Driver's license, IDNYC, or utility bills, rent/lease agreements, bank statements, official mail.	Any photo ID (including student, employee, or foreign cards/passports).	**No** (Only for children under 12).	Online registration offers instant digital-only card (geolocated address check); upgraded to physical card in-branch.	High. Teens (13-17) require no ID. Staff explicitly do not ask about immigration status.
Toronto Public Library (TPL)	**Highly Flexible**: Ontario Photo ID, utility bill, lease, or **mailed registration postcard** (sent by TPL to verify address).	Driver's license, passport, birth cert, PR card, student card, or health card.	**No** (Only for children under 13).	Online registration offers instant Digital Access Card (13+) for online resources.	High. Mailed postcard allows homeless or unleased residents to verify residency without official bills.
British Public Libraries (UK)	**Flexible**: Recent utility bill, council tax bill, bank statement, or tenancy agreement (3-6 months).	Passport, driving license, national ID, or student ID.	**No** (Only for children/youth under 14-18 depending on council).	Online registration gives a temporary number; in-person verification required for physical borrowing.	Medium-High. Most councils offer "basic" or "guest" cards with restricted limits for those without standard ID (e.g., refugees).

Library System	Residency Proof / Address Verification	ID Requirements	Guarantor Required for Adults?	Digital vs. Physical Access	Inclusion / Flexibility Features
Medellín (SBPM)	**Standard**: Proof of residency in the metropolitan area.	Cédula de ciudadanía, pasaporte, foreign card/permit.	**No** (Asks for 2 personal contact references, but no physical signature/liability).	Online pre-registration; in-person photo taken and linked to profile for cardless borrowing.	Medium. Photo-link simplifies access, though standard documentation is still required.
Cape Town (Library Services)	**Standard**: Recent city account statement or municipal bill.	ID book/card or passport.	**No** (Asks for 2 contact references in Cape Town, but no signature/liability).	Standard in-person registration (3-day processing time).	Medium. Non-residents/ex-pats can access services via a paid facilities fee.

14.1 Mechanisms of friction

When compared globally, the Indian library systems (Ahmedabad and Delhi) emerge as major outliers in their administrative barriers:

- **The proof-burden mismatch**: Ahmedabad's stated eligibility rule is residence in Ahmedabad city, but the actual proof rules are inconsistent and sometimes narrower than that standard. The older rules recognise several proofs; the membership blurb foregrounds Aadhaar; the online form reduces options to three KYC documents. A public library should make residence easy to verify, not convert residence into a biometric or platform dependency.
- **The attestation / guarantor barrier**: Ahmedabad requires a guarantor for adult membership. Delhi Public Library gates adult access through attestation by a Gazetted Officer, school principal, doctor, lawyer, bank manager, or RWA president, or else an INR 3,000 refundable security deposit. Both systems turn a public-service relationship into a test of social or financial capital, unlike the individual civil registration models used in New York, Toronto, Medellín, Cape Town, and many UK councils.
- **Digital dual-tracking**: Rather than using digital cards to reduce friction, Ahmedabad's digital workflow makes a mobile number and OTP central, while physical M.J. membership relies on KYC, guarantor details, and librarian approval. This creates separate surveillance vectors: mobile-number tracking for digital reading and document/social verification for physical membership.
- **Disproportionate burden by use case**: The strongest proof requirements may be defensible for high-risk borrowing, but they are excessive for low-risk uses such as reading-room access, reference consultation, public events, digital discovery, or browsing. Treating all use as if it creates the same loss risk undermines the public-library function.

The comparators carry a narrow, practical lesson: verification can serve convenience instead of surveillance. Toronto mails a registration postcard to a self-declared address; New York issues an instant card and instructs staff not to ask about immigration status; Medellín takes a photograph at the desk and links it to the reader's profile so they can borrow without carrying identification. None is a template to import wholesale, but each shows that confirming residence need not mean policing it by wealth or biometrics.

15 Governance: Who Runs It, and Is It Accountable?

Who runs a library, under what instrument, and with what public accountability shapes whether any of the earlier conditions can be enforced. The two Indian cases are governed differently and disclose their governance only partially. Delhi Public Library is a capital-city special case: a Union-linked system funded through the Ministry of Culture and run through the Delhi Library Board, serving local residents but not controlled through ordinary municipal government. Ahmedabad's M.J. Library network is municipal, but its public-facing governance is unsynchronised and incomplete — the live board roster does not match current AMC incumbency (Section 4), and the formal by-laws, current library-board membership, committee appointment dates, terms, and delegation of powers are not published.

Singapore is the lens for what accountable statutory governance can report. The National Library Board is a statutory board under the National Library Board Act 1995, supervised by the Ministry of Digital Development and Information; its 2024-25 annual report and About page give a network of 28 libraries:

Field	Value	Source
Libraries	28	NLB About page / Annual Report 2024-25
Visits	20.8 million	NLB Annual Report 2024-25
Total loans	38.8 million	NLB Annual Report 2024-25
Physical loans	24.0 million	NLB Annual Report 2024-25
Digital loans	14.8 million	NLB Annual Report 2024-25
Digital usage	89.2 million	NLB Annual Report 2024-25

Table sources: National Library Board official About page and NLB Annual Report 2024-25.[11]

A national or statutory-board model, in other words, is no excuse for thin reporting — and it forces the Indian cases to separate physical from digital access, which Ahmedabad and Delhi barely evidence at all (e-book loans, audio-book loans, downloads, digital usage).

Jakarta shows a different governance form and its characteristic risk. DISPUSIP DKI Jakarta is the provincial library and archives agency; the Jaklitera platform layers catalogue search, accounts, events, and mobile-library schedules over the network:

[11] NLB's 20.8 million visit figure includes the National Library, public libraries, National Archives, and the Former Ford Factory; it is not a pure branch-only public-library visit count.

Field	Evidence	Source
Governance	DISPUSIP DKI Jakarta is the provincial library and archives agency.	DISPUSIP profile
Flagship institution	Perpustakaan Jakarta Cikini and PDS HB Jassin became a dedicated management unit in 2022.	DISPUSIP library profile
Managed stationary locations	6 locations are served through Jaklitera, plus mobile library service.	DISPUSIP library services page
Wider registry	Jaklitera search exposed 5,239 registered library results, including RPTRA and school libraries.	Jaklitera library search
Digital layer	Jaklitera provides web/mobile catalog and service functions.	Perpustakaan Jakarta / Jaklitera portal

Jakarta shows how a capital-region digital platform can widen discovery and registration, but it does not yet provide a clean like-for-like service-point count against Ahmedabad or Delhi.[12]

16 Civic Intent: Is the Library Planned as Infrastructure?

The last condition is the most basic and the easiest to miss: whether a city plans its libraries as civic infrastructure at all, or merely maintains them as legacy departments. The Indian disclosure failure, the spatial neglect of the periphery, and the documentary gatekeeping point the same way — toward an institution kept on the books rather than designed around the public it is meant to serve.

Medellín is the lens for the opposite choice. The Sistema de Bibliotecas Públicas de Medellín treats its library parks as cultural-development centres planned as neighbourhood civic anchors:

Field	Value	Source
SBPM libraries	26	SBPM network page
Coverage	16 communes and 5 corregimientos	SBPM network page
2024 visitors	2,311,418	SBPM 2024 statistical consolidated PDF
2024 service/program participants	2,226,266	SBPM 2024 statistical consolidated PDF
Registered users by December 2024	320,771	SBPM 2024 statistical consolidated PDF

[12]The 5,239 Jaklitera results are a broad registered-library ecosystem that includes school and community facilities, not 5,239 public-library branches.

Field	Value	Source
Approximate 2024 lending	about 340,370	SBPM 2024 statistical consolidated PDF; preliminary extract
Approximate collection	about 1.26 million	SBPM 2024 statistical consolidated PDF; preliminary extract

Table sources: SBPM official About page, SBPM network page, and SBPM 2024 statistical consolidated PDF.

Medellín asks the question Ahmedabad and Delhi cannot avoid: is a library a planned civic anchor in a neighbourhood, or merely a room with books? Designing for the answer means siting libraries against ward population, transit, schools, bastis and resettlement colonies, heat, and public-space deficits — exactly the layers Section 13 found the Indian networks ignoring.

Shenzhen shows the same intent pursued at state scale. In 2009 the city launched a "City of Libraries" programme; in 2021 the National Development and Reform Commission named it the only cultural-field item in the Shenzhen Special Economic Zone reform list to be promoted nationwide, and it is the only city awarded UNESCO's "Global Model City for Promoting Reading."

Reported Shenzhen network figures:[13]

Field	Value	Source / scope
Public libraries	744 (incl. 9 national first-class)	Shenzhen Government / EYESHENZHEN portal
Self-service libraries	306 (200+ open 24-hour)	Shenzhen Government / EYESHENZHEN portal
Network collection	57.45 million books	Shenzhen Government / EYESHENZHEN portal
Per-capita reading (2020)	8.86 print + 12.13 e-books / person / year	Shenzhen official reading data, 2020
Main Shenzhen Library (2006)	~4.5 million visits, ~5 million loans / year	Shenzhen Government / EYESHENZHEN portal
Shenzhen Library North (opened Dec 2023)	2.0 million visits by July 2024	Shenzhen Government portal, 2024

Two features matter for the Indian cases. A single shared catalogue lets a reader borrow and return at any point, and a 24-hour self-service network detaches access from staffed opening hours — and so from the staffing collapse that cripples Delhi. And the per-capita reading figures show what a city measures when it treats reading as an outcome rather than counting buildings.

[13] These are headline figures published through PRC government and government-affiliated portals (Shenzhen Government Online, EYESHENZHEN), not an independently audited annual report with branch-level open data, and they carry a state-promotion register. As with Jakarta's registry, the "744 libraries / city of 1,000 libraries" count must not be read as 744 full staffed branches: it bundles small self-service kiosks and book-bars with full libraries, and is a programme-intensity benchmark rather than a like-for-like service-point count against Ahmedabad or Delhi.

17 Limitations and Future Work

The analysis above is limited by a common disclosure failure: both cities report institutions more clearly than services. The remaining gaps are not minor. They determine whether the library network can be evaluated as public infrastructure rather than as a list of buildings, boards, and annual totals.

A further limitation is methodological rather than evidentiary: the compilation and comparison scripts behind this analysis were AI-assisted, under human direction and review; an undetected coding error remains a residual risk alongside the disclosure gaps catalogued below.

The spatial analysis is also provisional. Ahmedabad's current map is a straight-line ward-centroid proxy rather than a population-weighted walking or transit model. Delhi's location layer covers all 111 working DPL rows, but part of the coordinate inventory still needs to be verified against DPL-published coordinates, official address material, or other open public-source evidence before the maps are treated as publication-final. These limits do not change the main finding that Delhi's fixed-library network is thin and unevenly distributed; they define the next standard of proof.

The international comparators carry their own evidence caveats. Their figures are drawn from official annual reports, government portals, and government-affiliated media at differing scopes and reporting standards — and, for Shenzhen, in a state-promotion register — so they are used as directional disclosure-and-intensity benchmarks, not as like-for-like service counts against the Indian cases.

For Ahmedabad, the unresolved fields are:

Field	Why
Branch-wise opening hours and weekly hours	To assess actual access, not nominal locations.
Seating capacity by branch	To assess study/reading-room capacity.
Branch collection size and collection type	To distinguish children's, reference, lending, periodical, digital, and special collections.
Branch staff and full-time staff	To map service capacity.
Physical visits and loans by branch	To identify active and inactive service points.
Internet access by branch	To complete IFLA internet-access metric.
Digital loans/downloads	To complete IFLA digital metrics.
M.J. Library Board by-laws, current board, terms, and librarian qualifications	To make governance auditable.

For Delhi, the unresolved fields are:

Field	Why
Branch-wise opening hours and weekly hours	DPL's hierarchy mixes fixed libraries and mobile stops; hours are essential.
Seating capacity by branch	Needed for reading-room and study-space adequacy.
Branch collection size and collection type	Needed to distinguish central, zonal, branch, sub-branch, Braille, and mobile service.

Field	Why
Staff posted by branch and sanctioned/filled/vacant posts by designation	Needed because system-wide vacancy is now nearly 50 percent.
Physical visits and loans by branch	Reading-room attendance is only a partial visits proxy.
Mobile service schedules, stop-level frequency, and usage	Needed because mobile stops are not equivalent to permanent branches.
Internet access by location	Needed for IFLA metric completion.
E-book, audio-book, and download metrics	Needed for digital service audit.
Delhi Library Board composition, powers, by-laws, appointment dates, and term lengths	Needed because DPL is a board-governed central public institution.

The Delhi parliamentary layer added in Section 5 is a first accountability pass, not an exhaustive Parliament audit. It covers the core Rajya Sabha answers on DPL, the National Mission on Libraries, RRRLF, Union-funded libraries, vacant posts, legislation, and the repeated State-subject deflection. The next pass should add Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee reports on Transport, Tourism and Culture where Culture-related oversight appears, and should reconcile annual-report staffing tables against any designation-level vacancy annexures tabled in Parliament.

18 Conclusion

All seven cities have public-library systems on paper. What the evidence shows is a public institution being quietly withdrawn — not abolished, but hollowed. The buildings, boards, and collections persist while the service inside them thins. Delhi's circulation has fallen from over 1.1 million issues a year to 274,751, and its staffing vacancy has climbed to nearly half. Ahmedabad registers barely 0.38 percent of its residents. Bengaluru and Hyderabad levy a library cess their municipal corporations then withhold — hundreds of crores in arrears — while the reading rooms decay. Kolkata legislated and catalogued a network of thousands, then, having dropped the cess, let its staff lapse. Mumbai's founding statute refused the cess for a grant floor now decayed to a token, and its 2024 amendment answered the shortfall not with public revenue but by capturing the library council and opening the fund to corporate charity. Only Chennai, funding reading by a dedicated buoyant cess, keeps the commons dense and disclosed. Read together, the library survives as an address and recedes as a service — and whether it recedes is decided, above all, by whether a city taxes itself to keep it.

That withdrawal is not evenly distributed. It falls first on the wards where the country's most excluded readers live. In Ahmedabad the wards farthest from a library are also the most deprived, and that deprivation sits on a caste geography. Mumbai — the one city whose ward data carries caste — lets the pattern be measured directly: its Scheduled-Caste and Scheduled-Tribe-reserved wards average a longer walk to a public library than the rest, and the M-East ward of Govandi and Deonar, the city's most segregated, is reached last of all. The residents least able to reach a branch are the same residents least able to satisfy an Aadhaar-and-guarantor or attestation-or-deposit membership test. Distance and paperwork compound. The one civic institution that should ask the least of the people who need it most is, in practice, gated hardest against them.

The international cases are not models to copy. They are evidence that this is a choice, not a law of urban life. Read across the five conditions, each isolates a decision the Indian cities have made the other way: Toronto discloses where they conceal, the membership comparators admit where they screen, Singapore reports where they stay opaque, and Medellín and Shenzhen plan the library as civic infrastructure where they let it lapse into a legacy department. A library can confirm a reader by mailing a postcard or taking a photograph at the desk; it does not have to demand a biometric, a guarantor, or a fortnight's wages held as deposit.

None of this requires the library to be closed — and that is the point. An institution can keep every building, board, and budget line and still be withdrawn as a public: withdrawn because the records that would show the withdrawal are the ones never kept, and because the gate that admits its public is set where the poorest and most caste-marked residents cannot clear it. The Indian public library has not failed. It has been quietly converted from an instrument meant to dissolve caste into one that, branch by branch and form by form, administers it.

Data and Code Availability

The derived data for this paper — the compiled 83-location Ahmedabad library inventory, the M.J. Library annual-statistics series (2015–16 to 2025–26), the Delhi Public Library service hierarchy, and the ward-centroid access surfaces built for Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Kolkata, and Mumbai (including, for Mumbai, the population- and caste-weighted prabhag cross) — together with the analysis code, are deposited in the Right to Read working-paper series' Open Science Framework (OSF) project, with the code archived for a citable, versioned DOI on Zenodo (DOIs to be assigned at public release). Primary sources are cited to their own repositories rather than re-hosted here: the M.J. Library / AMC official disclosures, the Delhi Public Library annual reports (2009–10 to 2023–24), the Greater Chennai Corporation library register, the state library-network disclosures, and the comparator city-library systems; the geocoded Kolkata and Mumbai surfaces are Google-Places-findable lower bounds assembled where no open per-branch register was reachable. The paper and the deposited derived data are released under CC-BY-NC-4.0 and the analysis code under the MIT License.

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